

STUDY GUIDE · FOUNDER SALES & CUSTOMER DEVELOPMENT

Sales & Customer Development for Founders

A Beginner-to-Advanced Study Guide — talk to customers, run discovery calls, handle "no", and sell without overselling

Prepared 2026-06-21 · Read the sections in order

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How to Use This Guide

Welcome. If the word "sales" makes you a little uncomfortable, you are in exactly the right place. Most technical founders feel the same way. You learned to build things. Nobody taught you to sell them. And the picture of "a salesperson" in your head, the pushy person who talks fast and twists arms, is probably not who you want to be. Good news: that person is not who good sellers actually are, and that is not what this guide will turn you into.

Let me define the two words in the title right away, in plain English.

- **Sales** means helping someone decide to buy something that genuinely helps them. At its core it is honest communication, not trickery.
- **Customer development** is a phrase from startup teacher Steve Blank. It means going out and talking to real people to learn whether your product solves a real problem *before* you bet everything on it. His famous line is "there are no facts inside the building, so get outside."

Key idea: Selling is a learnable skill, not a personality you are born with. Paul Graham of Y Combinator openly says he was "not very good" at sales but "persistent," and it worked. You do not need charm. You need curiosity, honesty, and a simple process. This guide gives you the process.

The promise of this guide

By the end, you will be able to do four things you may not be able to do comfortably today: (1) talk to potential customers and get the truth out of them instead of polite lies, (2) run a focused conversation that uncovers whether someone has a real problem worth paying to solve, (3) show your product in a way that lands as helpful rather than pushy, and (4) ask for a clear next step without feeling like a fraud.

How the guide is organized

The 14 chapters move in a deliberate order, from mindset to listening to the actual selling motion to building a habit.

- **Chapters 1–3** build the foundation: why founders must sell, how to "get out of the building," and how to talk to people without fooling yourself (the famous *Mom Test*).
- **Chapters 4–6** are the conversation craft: asking questions that do not lead the witness, listening actively, and running a great *discovery call* (a first conversation to understand someone's situation) from start to finish.
- **Chapters 7–9** are the professional toolkit: well-known sales frameworks (SPIN, BANT, MEDDIC), deciding who is worth your time, and giving a demo that shows value.
- **Chapters 10–11** handle the scary parts: objections and the word "no."
- **Chapters 12–14** are how you keep it going: getting conversations in the first place, moving a deal toward a yes, and turning all of this into a steady habit.

How to read it

Read Chapters 1 through 6 in order; they build on each other. After that you can jump to whatever you need next. Do not try to master everything before you start. The single fastest way to get better is to read one chapter, then go have one real conversation. Steve Blank's whole method assumes you will get it wrong a few times and learn each round. That is the point, not a failure.

Best practice: Keep a running notes doc. After every customer conversation, write down the exact words they used to describe their problem. Their words become your sales copy, your product priorities, and your confidence.

The mindset to bring

Drop the idea that selling is something you do *to* people. The mindset that makes shy founders into effective sellers is this: *I am a curious detective trying to find out if I can genuinely help this person. If I can, I will say so. If I cannot, I will tell them honestly.* That stance is comfortable for technical people because it is just truth-seeking, the same instinct that makes you a good engineer.

Common mistake: Waiting until the product is "ready" before talking to anyone. The biggest risk in a startup is not building a buggy product, it is building one nobody wants. Conversations are how you find out, and they cost nothing but a little courage.

Be patient with yourself. Your first calls will feel awkward. Everyone's do. By call ten you will sound like a different person. Let's begin.

1. Why Founders Must Learn to Sell (And Why It Is Learnable)

Let's start with a confession that probably feels true for you: the word "sales" makes you a little uncomfortable. Maybe it brings up an image of a pushy car salesman, a cold caller who won't take no for an answer, or someone smiling too much while they try to talk you into something you don't need. If that's you, good news. This whole guide is written for you. And this first chapter has one job: to change how you feel about selling, so the rest becomes possible.

Quick definitions before we go further, because we'll use these words a lot:

Selling

Helping another person make a good decision about whether your product solves their problem. That's it. Not tricking. Not pressuring. Helping someone decide.

Founder-led sales

When the person who built the company (you) personally talks to customers and closes the early deals, instead of hiring a salesperson to do it.

A prospect

A person or company who might become a customer. You're not selling *to* them; you're figuring out *with* them whether there's a fit.

What selling actually is (and what it is not)

Author Daniel Pink studied this for his book *To Sell Is Human*. His conclusion: selling, done right, is not sleazy or manipulative. It is a form of **service**. You are moving someone from a worse situation to a better one. A doctor "sells" you on taking a medicine that helps you. A good teacher "sells" a student on why a topic matters. None of that is dirty. It's helpful.

Pink describes the modern skill of selling with three qualities, which he calls the new ABCs:

- **Attunement** — seeing the situation from the other person's point of view.
- **Buoyancy** — staying positive even though you'll hear "no" a lot. (Buoyancy means staying afloat, like a cork on water.)
- **Clarity** — helping someone see a problem they hadn't fully noticed, and see it in a fresh way.

Key idea: Selling is not "convincing someone to buy something." It is helping the right person make a good decision — which sometimes means helping them decide *not* to buy. When you believe that, the discomfort fades.

Analogy: Think of yourself as a doctor, not a street vendor. A street vendor wants to sell you whatever is on the cart today. A doctor asks where it hurts, runs a few tests, and only then says, "Here's what I think will help — and if it won't, I'll tell you that too." People trust doctors precisely because they diagnose before they prescribe. That's the founder you're going to become.

The biggest mindset shift: from "convince" to "discover & diagnose"

Here is the single most freeing idea in this guide. Bad selling tries to **convince**. Good selling tries to **discover and diagnose**. The difference changes everything, including how it feels to do it.

Old idea: "Convince"	New idea: "Discover & diagnose"
You do most of the talking	They do most of the talking
Goal: get them to say yes	Goal: understand if it's a real fit
You pitch your features	You ask about their problems
Pressure and closing tricks	Curiosity and honest questions
Feels gross	Feels like a helpful conversation

This isn't a soft opinion. Neil Rackham proved it with data. For his book *SPIN Selling*, his team analyzed more than **35,000 real sales calls**. The finding: the best performers were not the smooth talkers with slick pitches. They were the ones who asked smart, purposeful questions and let the buyer uncover their own needs. Rackham even found that aggressive, hard-closing tactics *backfire* on bigger, more considered purchases — the kind you'll usually be making. (We'll learn his actual question framework later in the guide.)

Example — same moment, two versions:

Convince mode: "Our tool has automated reporting, real-time dashboards, and 40 integrations. It's the best on the market. You should really try it."

Discover mode: "Walk me through how you handle reporting today. Where does that get painful? What happens when it goes wrong?"

The second one feels easy to say out loud, doesn't it? You're just curious. That's the whole trick.

Why no one else can do this for you (yet)

You might be hoping you can skip all this by hiring a salesperson early. Please don't. At the start, founder-led sales is non-negotiable, and here's the honest reason: a hired salesperson can repeat a script, but they can't *learn the market for you*. In the early days you don't yet know exactly what you're selling, to whom, or why they'll pay. The only way to find out is to hear it directly, in your own ears, from real prospects.

Startup teacher Steve Blank built an entire method around this called **Customer Development**, summed up in one famous phrase: **"Get out of the building."** His point is that no plan survives first contact with customers, so you must go talk to them, get ignored, get corrected, and learn what's actually true. You can't outsource that learning. It has to come through *your* mouth and *your* ears.

This is also why Y Combinator (the famous startup school) tells founders to **"do things that don't scale"** and "talk to your users." When Airbnb was tiny, the founders personally knocked on doors asking people to list their homes. That wasn't a waste of the founders' time — it *was* the work. Every awkward conversation taught them something a spreadsheet never could.

```
YOU TALK TO A PROSPECT
|
you hear a real problem  -----> change the PRODUCT
|                               (only a founder can!)
you hear the words they use -----> change your PITCH
|
you hear an objection  -----> learn what's missing
|
v
you understand the market better than anyone
```

Your unfair advantages as a founder

You think a professional salesperson would do this better than you. In the early stage, the opposite is usually true. You have advantages no hired rep can match:

- **Real passion.** You built this because you cared. People feel that, and it's persuasive in an honest way.
- **Deep product knowledge.** You can answer any hard question on the spot, with no "let me check with the team."
- **You can change the product.** This is the big one. If a prospect says "I'd buy it if it did X," *you can actually go build X*. A salesperson can only say "I'll pass that along." You can say "Let me build that and come back to you."
- **Credibility.** "I'm the founder, I made this" opens doors that a sales title never will. Many buyers feel flattered to talk to the person who built the thing.

Best practice: Lead with your founder status, not despite it. Try: "Hi, I'm the founder — I built this and I'm trying to learn whether it actually helps people like you. Could I ask you a few questions about how you handle [problem] today?" Honest, disarming, and it gets a "yes" far more often than a polished pitch.

"But I'm an introvert / I'm bad at this"

Let's kill the biggest myth right now: **selling is not a personality trait you're born with. It's a skill you build, like a muscle.** The loud, charming extrovert is not the best salesperson — remember Rackham's

35,000 calls showed the *best* sellers were the careful question-askers and listeners. That's literally the introvert's home turf.

Consider Rob Fitzpatrick, author of *The Mom Test* (a book we'll lean on heavily for talking to customers). He describes himself as a programmer who was far more comfortable behind a screen than in a meeting — and he was *forced* to learn enterprise sales at his first startup. He didn't have a "sales gene." He learned a method. So can you.

Common mistake: Waiting until you "feel ready" or "feel confident" to start talking to customers. Confidence comes *after* reps, not before. The fastest way to stop fearing sales conversations is to have ten of them. The discomfort shrinks every single time.

And here's the part that should calm your nerves the most. Because good selling is just *asking honest questions and listening*, you don't need charisma, a fake smile, or a clever script. You need genuine curiosity about another human's problem. If you can be curious, you can sell. You already have everything required.

What this guide will give you

Over the coming chapters, we'll turn this mindset into concrete skills. You'll learn how to talk to customers without getting lied to (The Mom Test), how to ask diagnostic questions that uncover real needs (SPIN), how to run a discovery call, how to handle "it's too expensive" and "I need to think about it" without flinching, how to follow up, and how to close in a way that feels clean. Every chapter will hand you actual sentences you can copy and say out loud.

Key idea: You are not becoming a "salesperson." You are becoming a founder who can sit across from a customer, understand their world, and honestly help them decide. That is a learnable skill — and it's the most important one you'll build at this stage.

Key takeaways

- **Selling is serving** — helping the right person make a good decision, including helping them say no when it's not a fit. (Daniel Pink, *To Sell Is Human*.)
- The core shift is from "**convince**" to "**discover & diagnose**." Talk less, ask more, listen most. Rackham's 35,000-call study proved questions beat pitches.
- **Founder-led sales can't be outsourced early** — you learn the market through your own mouth and ears. "Get out of the building" (Steve Blank); "do things that don't scale" (YC).
- You have **unfair advantages**: passion, total product knowledge, founder credibility, and the power to actually change the product when a prospect asks.
- **Selling is a muscle, not a personality.** Introverts who listen carefully often sell best. *The Mom Test*'s author started as a screen-shy programmer.

- **Confidence comes after reps, not before.** Don't wait to feel ready — start the conversations now.
- If you can be genuinely **curious about someone's problem**, you already have everything you need to begin.

2. Customer Development: Get Out of the Building

Here is the most common way technical founders fail. They have an idea. They love it. They sit at their desk for six months and build it. They launch. And nobody comes. The product works perfectly. It just solves a problem that no one will pay to fix.

This chapter is the cure. It teaches you a simple, proven way to find out whether your idea is real *before* you waste months building the wrong thing. The method is called **Customer Development**. The slogan you must tattoo on your brain is "**Get out of the building.**"

Key idea: Inside your building (your desk, your code editor, your head) there are only guesses. The facts that decide whether your business lives or dies live *outside* the building, in the heads of real customers. Your job is to go get those facts.

Where this idea comes from (the real people and books)

You do not have to invent this. Two famous thinkers already mapped it out, and their work is now the standard playbook in Silicon Valley.

- **Steve Blank** is a serial entrepreneur and Stanford/Berkeley teacher. In his book *The Four Steps to the Epiphany* (2005) he created **Customer Development** and the phrase "**get out of the building.**" His big point: building a product is a known engineering process, but *finding customers* is a process of *discovery* that has to happen face-to-face, outside.
- **Eric Ries** was a startup founder who studied under Blank. His book *The Lean Startup* (2011) turned these ideas into a loop any founder can run. He gave us two terms we will use constantly: **Build-Measure-Learn** and **validated learning**.

Let me define those two Ries terms in plain words right now, because we use them throughout.

Build-Measure-Learn

A repeating cycle. You build the smallest thing that tests an idea, you measure how real customers react, and you learn whether your guess was right. Then you go around again.

Validated learning

Progress measured not by "we wrote more code" but by "we learned something true about customers, proven by their actual behavior." Writing 5,000 lines of code that nobody wants is *zero* progress. Learning that nobody wants it (after one week of conversations) is *real* progress.

Analogy: Building before talking to customers is like cooking a huge dinner for 50 guests without asking if any of them are hungry, what they like, or whether they're even coming. The smart cook asks first, then cooks. Customer Development is asking first.

The four steps (a beginner's overview)

Blank splits the early life of a company into four steps. As a solo founder you mostly live in step one for a long time. But it helps to see the whole map.

1. **Customer Discovery** — Go find out if the problem you imagine is a problem real people actually have, and badly enough to want a fix. *This is where you spend almost all your early time. This chapter is mostly about this step.*
2. **Customer Validation** — Prove people will actually *pay*, and find a repeatable way to sell. (Can you get a few real customers using a sales process you could do again?)
3. **Customer Creation** — Now that selling works, spend money to create demand and bring in more customers (marketing, ads, growth).
4. **Company Building** — Switch from "search mode" to "run a company mode": hire teams, build departments, scale up.

Blank's deep insight: steps 1 and 2 are a **search** for a business model. Steps 3 and 4 are **execution** of one you've already found. Most startups die because they jump straight to execution (hiring, spending, scaling) before they've actually *found* something that works. And the model expects you to **loop back**: you will go around discovery and validation several times before it clicks. As Blank puts it, it's okay to mess up — as long as you plan to learn from it.

Two finish lines: problem/solution fit, then product/market fit

You will hear two phrases everywhere. They are simply two milestones, in order.

Problem/Solution Fit (the first milestone)

You have proof that a real, painful problem exists *and* that your proposed solution would plausibly fix it. You go from *hoping* people want this to having evidence they do — before building the full thing.

Product/Market Fit (the bigger, later milestone)

Your actual, built product satisfies a real market so well that demand pulls you forward — people keep buying, keep using, and tell others. This is the famous moment a startup is "working."

You cannot skip to the second. Problem/solution fit is the foundation product/market fit is built on. Customer Discovery is how you reach the first milestone cheaply, mostly through conversations.

```
TALK to customers — reach —> PROBLEM/SOLUTION FIT
    (cheap, fast)           "Yes, real pain. Fix makes sense."
                           |
                           then BUILD
                           |
                           v
USE real product — reach —> PRODUCT/MARKET FIT
    (the built thing)       "The market pulls; demand is real."
```

Turn your idea into testable guesses (hypotheses)

A **hypothesis** is just a fancy word for a *specific guess you can check*. Right now your idea is a big fuzzy belief. The first move is to break it into small, sharp guesses, each one you can test by talking to people.

Don't write: "Print shops need better software." That's too vague to test. Instead break it down:

- **Who** exactly has the problem? ("Owners of small print shops with 2–10 staff.")
- **What** painful thing happens today? ("They re-key online orders into their machines by hand and make costly mistakes.")
- **How much** does it hurt? ("They lose time and money on reprints every week.")
- **What** do they do about it now? ("They use spreadsheets and sticky notes.")

Best practice: Write each guess as a sentence you can mark true or false after 10 conversations.

"Small print shop owners lose at least an hour a day re-typing online orders by hand" is a hypothesis.

"My product is great" is not.

Why this happens BEFORE and ALONGSIDE building — not after

Here is the trap technical founders fall into: "I'll just build it, then ask people." By then you've spent your scarcest resource (months of your life) betting on an untested guess. Customer Development flips the order. You test the riskiest guesses with cheap conversations *first*. Then you keep talking to customers *while* you build, so every feature is steered by real feedback. Talking to customers is never a one-time phase you finish. It runs forever, beside the code.

Common mistake: Treating "talk to customers" as something you do once at the start, tick off, and never return to. The founders who win make it a permanent weekly habit, even after launch.

How this is different from a market research survey

You might think: "I'll just send out a survey." Be careful. Surveys and Customer Development are not the same thing, and surveys are weaker for an early idea.

Market research survey	Customer Development conversation
Many people, shallow, fixed questions	Few people (10–15), deep, follow-up questions
Asks for opinions and "would you?"	Asks about real past behavior
You can't dig into a surprising answer	You ask "why?" and discover things you never expected
People say what sounds nice	You hunt for facts that can't be faked

This connects to the single most useful book on customer conversations: ***The Mom Test* by Rob Fitzpatrick**. The title comes from this: even your mom will lie to you about your idea, to protect your feelings. So you must ask questions even your mom couldn't lie about. Fitzpatrick gives three rules:

1. **Talk about *their* life, not your idea.** (The moment you pitch, they start being polite.)
2. **Ask about specifics in the *past*, not opinions about the future.** ("Would you use this?" is worthless. "When did you last hit this problem, and what did you do?" is gold.)
3. **Talk less, listen more.**

Key idea: Opinions are worthless; behavior is everything. "I would totally buy that" is a polite opinion. "I paid \$200 last month for a tool that didn't work" is a hard fact about real behavior. Chase the facts.

A concrete example: testing one assumption with 12 people

Say you're building software for small print shops (sound familiar?). Your riskiest guess is: *"Shop owners lose real money re-typing online orders by hand."* Here's how you test it without writing code.

You find 12 print shop owners (call, email, visit, ask for intros). You meet each for 20 minutes. You do **not** pitch. You ask Mom-Test questions:

Example dialogue:

You: "Walk me through what happens when an order comes in from your website."

Owner: "Oh, it's a nightmare. I print the email, then type it all into our machine software again."

You: "When was the last time that went wrong?"

Owner: "Last Tuesday. I fat-fingered a quantity, printed 500 instead of 50. Ate the cost myself."

You: "Wow. How often does something like that happen?"

Owner: "Couple times a month, honestly."

You: "What have you tried to fix it?"

Owner: "I made a checklist. Doesn't really help."

You: "Have you ever paid for anything to solve this?"

Owner: "I looked at a tool once but it was built for big factories. Too expensive, too complex."

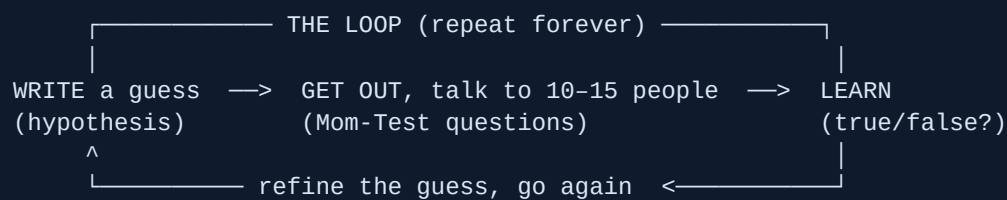
Notice what you got: a real story, a recent date, a dollar cost, a current workaround, and proof they already tried (and failed) to solve it. That's validated learning. After 12 of these, you'll see a pattern. Maybe 9 of 12 describe the same painful re-typing. Now your guess is *validated* — and you also learned the magic words real owners use ("nightmare," "fat-fingered," "built for big factories"), which become your marketing copy later.

Best practice: After each chat, write down (1) the most surprising thing you heard, (2) any real story with a date or dollar amount, and (3) whether your guess looks more true or more false. Ten to fifteen conversations is usually enough to spot a clear pattern.

"Do things that don't scale" — getting your first users by hand

Paul Graham (co-founder of startup accelerator Y Combinator) wrote a famous 2013 essay, *Do Things That Don't Scale*. His advice pairs perfectly with Customer Development. At the start you should recruit users **manually, one by one**, and delight them by hand — even in ways you could never repeat for a million users.

His favorite example: the Airbnb founders flew to New York and went door-to-door, signing up hosts and even taking professional photos of their apartments themselves. Totally unscalable. Exactly right for the start. Y Combinator boils its whole philosophy down to two jobs for an early founder: **"Write code and talk to users."** For you, the introvert technical founder, the uncomfortable half of that sentence is the more important one.



Key takeaways

- **Get out of the building.** The facts that decide your fate live in customers' heads, not at your desk. Talk to real people before and while you build.
- Customer Development (Steve Blank) has four steps — Discovery, Validation, Creation, Company Building — but as a solo founder you live mostly in **Discovery** for a long time.
- Aim for **problem/solution fit first** (cheap, via conversations), then **product/market fit** later (with the built product). Don't skip the first.
- Turn your fuzzy idea into **specific, testable guesses (hypotheses)** you can mark true or false after about a dozen conversations.
- Use **The Mom Test**: ask about their real past behavior, not opinions about your idea. Opinions are worthless; behavior is everything.
- Surveys give you shallow opinions; **deep conversations** give you facts, stories, and the customer's own words.
- Follow Paul Graham: **do things that don't scale** and remember the two jobs of an early founder — *write code and talk to users*.

3. The Mom Test: Talk to Customers Without Fooling Yourself

You have an idea you believe in. You're nervous about selling, but everyone says, "Talk to customers first." So you do. You describe your product, and people say, "Wow, that sounds great!" You walk away glowing. Months later, you launch, and... nobody buys.

What happened? You got *fooled*. Not by liars, but by polite people. This chapter is about a small, famous book that fixes this exact problem: **The Mom Test** by **Rob Fitzpatrick**. The book teaches you how to talk to potential customers so you learn the truth instead of collecting flattering lies.

First, a definition. A **customer conversation** (sometimes called a "customer interview" or "discovery call") is just a talk where you try to understand someone's problems, before you've built or sold anything. **Discovery** means digging up the real story of how someone lives and works. That's the whole job in this chapter.

Key idea: Almost everyone will lie to you about your idea — politely, kindly, and without meaning to. The fix is to stop asking about your idea at all, and instead ask about *their life*. The truth lives in what people have already *done*, not in what they say they'll do.

Why people lie to you (and don't even know it)

The book is named after a simple truth: if you ask your mom, "Mom, do you think my business idea is good?" she will say yes. She loves you. She doesn't want to hurt your feelings. She has no idea if it's actually good — but she'll cheer anyway.

Here's the uncomfortable part: **everyone** does this, not just your mom. Strangers do it too. When you pitch your idea, people sense you're emotionally invested. The kind thing to do is encourage you. So they say "I'd totally use that" — and then never do.

Analogy: Asking "Do you like my idea?" is like asking someone "Do I look nice today?" Almost nobody will say "No, you look terrible." The polite default is yes. So a "yes" tells you nothing. You have to find a question where the polite answer and the honest answer are the same.

Fitzpatrick's clever insight is in the title: a good set of questions should pass "**the mom test**" — meaning, your questions should be so well-designed that *even your own mom couldn't lie to you*, because you never ask her opinion of your idea. You only ask about facts from her life.

The three rules of the Mom Test

The entire book boils down to three rules. Memorize these. Write them on a sticky note before every call.

1. **Talk about THEIR life, not YOUR idea.** The moment you describe your product, you've poisoned the conversation. Now they're reacting to *you*, being polite to *you*. Keep the spotlight on their world: their problems, their day, their frustrations.
2. **Ask about specifics in the PAST, not generics about the FUTURE.** People are wildly over-optimistic about the future. "Would you use this?" gets a hopeful guess. "What did you do the last time this happened?" gets a fact. The past actually happened. The future is a daydream.
3. **Talk LESS, listen MORE.** The more you talk, the more you steer them and the less you learn. Your job is to be curious and quiet. A good rule: they should talk far more than you do.

BAD CONVERSATION

You: pitch your idea --->
Them: compliment
You: feel great --->
Result: false hope

GOOD CONVERSATION

You: ask about their life
Them: tell a real story
You: learn a hard fact
Result: real knowledge

Good data vs. bad data: what to actually believe

"Data" here just means the things people tell you. The problem is that some of it is gold and some is garbage. The Mom Test sorts it for you.

Bad data (ignore it — it feels good but means nothing):

- **Compliments.** "That's a great idea!" "I love this!" Fitzpatrick calls compliments "the fluff" — they're free candy: sweet, but zero nutrition.
- **Opinions and hypotheticals.** Anything starting with "I would," "I could," "I might." A guess about an imaginary future.
- **Promises about the future.** "I'd definitely buy that." "Send it to me when it's ready." A promise costs nothing to make, so it's worth nothing.
- **Wishlists.** "It should also do X and Y." People are bad at designing solutions; treat feature requests as clues to a problem, not orders.

Good data (believe this — it's the truth):

- **Facts about the past.** What actually happened, step by step.
- **Past behavior.** What they've already tried, used, or built to cope.
- **Money already spent.** Tools they pay for, people they've hired, workarounds they've bought.
- **Time already spent.** Hours wasted, hacks built in spreadsheets, late nights.

Key idea: Stories are facts; opinions are guesses. If someone has already spent real time or real money fighting a problem, that problem is real. If they only say they care, you've learned nothing yet.

Good questions vs. bad questions (steal these word-for-word)

Bad question (gets lies)	Good question (gets truth)
"Do you think this is a good idea?"	"Talk me through the last time you ran into this."
"Would you buy a product that did X?"	"How are you dealing with this problem today?"
"Would you pay \$50/month for this?"	"What have you already tried to fix it? What did that cost you?"
"Do you like this feature?"	"What happens if you don't solve this? Why does it matter?"
"How often do you have this problem?"	"When was the last time it happened? Walk me through that day."

Notice the pattern. Bad questions ask for a verdict on your idea. Good questions ask for a **true story** from their past. You can't fake "the last time it happened" — it either happened or it didn't.

Best practice: Three questions will carry most of your calls: **"Talk me through the last time that happened."** · **"How do you deal with it now?"** · **"What have you tried, and how much did it cost you in time or money?"** Lead with these and just keep asking "why?" and "tell me more."

Why "Would you buy this?" is a useless question

This is the single most common mistake, so let's kill it clearly. "Would you buy this?" asks someone to predict their own future behavior *and* be polite to your face at the same time. They'll almost always say yes. That yes has cost them nothing — no money, no commitment, no risk. It's pure hot air.

Instead of asking what they'd do in the future, look at what they've already done. Replace it with questions like:

- "What are you currently using to handle this?"
- "How much does that cost you — in dollars or hours?"
- "Who else is involved when you try to solve this?"
- "Last time it broke, what did you do about it?"

Common mistake: Treating "I would definitely buy that!" as validation. It's the most dangerous sentence in customer research because it feels exactly like a win. The only thing that proves real interest is a *commitment* — giving up something of value right now: their money (a pre-order or deposit), their time (a real next meeting with a goal), their reputation (introducing you to their boss or a peer), or specific personal data. No commitment means it was just a compliment in disguise.

How to deflect compliments and dig for the real story

When a compliment lands, don't bask in it — bounce off it and dig. Here's how, with lines you can say out loud:

They say: "This is such a cool idea!"

You say: "Thanks! Out of curiosity, is this something you actually run into? When did it last bite you?"

They say: "I'd totally use this."

You say: "I appreciate that. What are you using right now to get this done?"

They say: "You should add a calendar feature."

You say: "Interesting — what would that help you do that you can't do today? Walk me through it."

Spotting and avoiding "the pitch"

The pitch is when you slip into selling mode — explaining your idea and hoping they say yes. The Mom Test's golden rule: *during discovery, do not pitch*. The moment you start describing your product, you've stopped learning and started fishing for compliments. Signs you're pitching: you're talking more than them, you're saying "so basically my product...", or you feel the urge to defend your idea. Catch yourself and pivot back to a question about their life.

Example — bad conversation (a founder pitching):

You: "So I'm building an app that automatically schedules your print jobs and saves you tons of time.

Pretty cool, right?"

Them: "Oh wow, yeah, that sounds really useful!"

You: "Would you use something like that?"

Them: "Definitely, send it to me when it's ready!"

You: "Awesome!" *(You leave thrilled. You learned nothing. You got three compliments, one hypothetical, and one empty promise.)*

Example — good conversation (same founder, Mom Test style):

You: "How do you handle scheduling your print jobs right now?"

Them: "Honestly? A whiteboard and a messy spreadsheet."

You: "Talk me through the last time that went wrong."

Them: "Last Tuesday. Two big orders collided, we missed a deadline, and I had to refund a client \$400 and apologize for an hour."

You: "Ouch. How often does that kind of thing happen?"

Them: "Couple times a month. I've even paid a freelancer to babysit the schedule."

You: "How much does that cost you?"

Them: "About \$600 a month, and it still slips."

(No pitch. No compliments. You learned the problem is real, painful, frequent, and already costing \$600/month plus refunds. THAT is a business signal.)

See the difference? In the bad version you talked and got flattered. In the good version you listened and got facts, frequency, pain, and money already spent. One of these tells you whether to build. The other just feels nice.

Best practice: After every call, write down only the *facts and commitments* you heard — not the compliments. If your notes are all "they loved it," you ran a bad call. If your notes have real stories, costs, and a concrete next step, you ran a great one. As a solo technical founder who dreads selling, this is freeing: you don't have to be a smooth talker. You just have to be genuinely curious and quiet.

Key takeaways

- People lie to you politely about your idea — so never ask their opinion of it. Ask about their life instead.
- The three rules: talk about **their life not your idea**; ask about **specifics in the past not the future**; **talk less, listen more**.
- Bad data = compliments, opinions, hypotheticals, promises, and wishlists. Good data = facts, past behavior, and time or money already spent.
- "Would you buy this?" is useless — it costs them nothing to say yes. Ask what they do *today* and what it has already cost them.
- Deflect every compliment by digging: "Thanks — when did this last happen to you?"
- Never pitch during discovery. If you're talking more than they are, you've stopped learning.
- The only real proof of interest is a commitment of money, time, reputation, or a referral — not enthusiasm.

4. Asking Questions Without Leading

A sales conversation is really a conversation made of questions. The better your questions, the more truth you get back. And truth is the only thing worth selling on. This chapter teaches you the craft of asking, step by step, from the simplest building block to the advanced moves the pros use.

Here is the good news for you, the founder who dreads selling: asking good questions is not about being smooth or charming. It is about being curious. If you are genuinely curious about another person's problem, you are already most of the way there.

Key idea: Your job in a sales or discovery conversation is to *learn the truth*, not to hear "yes". A leading question gives you a fake "yes". A neutral question gives you real information you can build a business on.

The two basic kinds of questions

Every question you ask is either **open** or **closed**. Learn the difference and you control the whole conversation.

Open question

A question that cannot be answered with one word. It invites a story. It usually starts with *what, how, why, tell me, walk me through, describe*. Example: "How do you handle reprints when a customer rejects a proof?"

Closed question

A question answered with "yes", "no", or one fact. It starts with *do, did, is, are, have, would, how many, when*. Example: "Do you offer reprints?"

Both are useful. Open questions **open up** the conversation and get people talking. Closed questions **pin down** a specific fact once you need it ("So you printed 4,000 flyers last month, correct?"). The mistake beginners make is asking mostly closed questions, which turns a conversation into a quiz and teaches you almost nothing.

Best practice: Aim to do about 80% listening and 20% talking. If you are talking more than your customer, you are pitching, not discovering. Start with open questions; reach for closed ones only to confirm a detail.

The poison: leading questions

A **leading question** is a question that hints at the answer you want. It quietly tells the other person, "Here is what I'm hoping you'll say." Most people are polite. They will give you the answer you fished for, just to be nice. You walk away thrilled and completely misinformed.

This is the core warning from Rob Fitzpatrick's book *The Mom Test*. The title comes from a simple truth: if you ask your mom whether your business idea is good, she'll say yes, because she loves you. The fix is to ask questions so neutral that even your mom couldn't lie to you. Fitzpatrick's three rules are: **talk about their life, not your idea; ask about specific things in the past, not opinions about the future; and listen more, talk less.**

Common mistake: Pitching disguised as a question. "Wouldn't it be great if there was a tool that did X?" is not research. It is a compliment trap. Everyone says "sure, sounds great", nobody pays, and you build the wrong thing for six months.

Before-and-after: turning leading questions neutral

Read these out loud. Notice how the "after" version stops fishing and starts learning.

Leading (poisoned)	Neutral (clean)
"Do you think this would save you time?"	"How long does that task take you today?"
"Wouldn't it be useful to automate your invoices?"	"Walk me through how you send invoices now."
"Is pricing a real headache for you?"	"Tell me about the last time you set a price for a custom job."
"Would you pay \$50 a month for this?"	"What do you spend on this problem today, in tools or time?"
"You'd love a faster checkout, right?"	"What happened the last time a customer abandoned their cart?"
"Don't you hate doing this manually?"	"What's the most frustrating part of your week?"

See the pattern? The clean versions ask about **the actual past** ("the last time", "today", "now"). The past is fact. The future is a daydream, and people are wildly optimistic about what they'll do and pay "someday".

Analogy: A leading question is like asking a witness, "You saw the blue car run the light, didn't you?" Any good lawyer objects, because you planted the answer. A good discovery call works like a fair interview: "What did you see?" Let the witness tell you. Their unprompted answer is the only evidence that counts.

The funnel technique: broad to narrow

Don't fire questions randomly. Move like a funnel: start **wide** to find where the energy is, then go **narrow** into the juicy part. This mirrors how Neil Rackham's famous *SPIN Selling* works (built on research across 35,000+ sales calls): you ask in a deliberate order rather than blurting your pitch.

```
WIDE    "Tell me about how you run the print shop."
|       (find a topic where they light up)
v
----    "You mentioned proofs are a pain. Tell me more."
|       (zoom into the one juicy problem)
v
NARROW  "Walk me through the last proof that got rejected."
        (get the specific, real, recent story)
```

SPIN names four question types you can layer in once you find a real problem:

1. **Situation** - context. "How many orders do you handle a week?" (Ask few of these; don't interrogate.)
2. **Problem** - difficulties. "Where does that process break down?"
3. **Implication** - the cost of the problem. "When proofs get rejected, what does that do to your delivery dates?" This is the powerful one: it helps the person *feel* the size of the pain in their own words.
4. **Need-payoff** - the value of fixing it. "If that never happened again, what would change for you?"
Notice: *they* describe the value, so it isn't your sales pitch, it's their conclusion.

The most underrated skill: silence

After you ask a real question, **stop talking**. Count to five in your head. The pause feels painful to you, but to the other person it's just thinking time. Most people, given a few seconds of silence, will keep going and tell you the deeper, truer thing they were holding back.

Common mistake: Rescuing the silence. You ask a great question, the person pauses, and you panic and add, "...like, is it the cost, or the time, or...?" You just handed them easy answers and buried the real one. Ask, then zip it.

Example:

You: "What's the hardest part of fulfilling a rush order?"

Them: "Honestly... the timing, I guess." (*pause — you say nothing for 4 seconds*)

Them: "...okay, the real problem is I have no idea where the job is on the floor. I have to physically walk over and ask Dave. Twice a day. It drives me insane."

That second sentence — the gold — only came because you stayed quiet.

Follow-up probes: how to dig deeper

You rarely get the truth on the first answer. You get it on the third. Keep a handful of gentle **probes** ready. A probe is a short phrase that asks for more without changing the subject.

- "Tell me more about that."
- "What happened next?"
- "Why was that hard?"

- "Walk me through the last time that happened."
- "What did you do about it?" (If they did nothing, the pain may be small. Real pain makes people act.)
- "How often does that come up?"
- "What did that cost you — in time, money, or stress?"

Best practice: Listen for the "last time they tried to solve it themselves" — a clumsy spreadsheet, a hired temp, a half-built script. That's proof the pain is real and they have budget. People only hack around problems that genuinely hurt.

The 5 Whys: reaching the root cause

When you hit a problem, ask "why" up to five times, each "why" aimed at the last answer. This technique comes from Sakichi Toyoda at Toyota and is used to find the *root* cause, not just the symptom. Here it is in a sales conversation:

Example (5 Whys in the wild):

"We lose customers after the first order." → **Why?**

"They say reordering is annoying." → **Why?**

"They have to re-upload their artwork every time." → **Why?**

"We don't save their files anywhere they can reach." → **Why?**

"Our system has no customer account area." → **Why?**

"We never built one because we didn't think it mattered."

Root cause found. The "churn problem" is really a "no saved-design library" problem — something you can actually build and sell.

Use it gently in conversation — five blunt "whys" in a row feels like an interrogation. Soften them: "Huh, why's that?", "And what's behind that?", "What causes that to happen?"

Two question shapes to avoid

Double-barreled questions

Two questions jammed into one. "Do you struggle with pricing and inventory?" The person answers one and ignores the other, and you can't tell which. Ask one thing at a time. Split it: "Tell me about pricing." (*then later*) "Now, inventory — how's that going?"

Jargon questions

Questions stuffed with your own insider words. "How do you handle your fulfillment-pipeline throughput?" Your customer hears noise. Use *their* words: "What happens from when an order comes in to when it ships?"

Asking about money without scaring people

Founders freeze up on money questions. The trick: don't ask "would you pay?" (a future fantasy). Ask about money they **already spend** today. Spending is fact; willingness is fiction.

- "How are you solving this today – and what does that cost you?"
- "Is there a budget for this already, or would you have to create one?"
- "Who would need to sign off on a purchase like this?"
- "What would have to be true for this to be worth paying for?"
- "When something like this costs you a customer, what's that worth to you?"

Best practice: Frame price against the pain, not against your costs. "You said a rejected proof costs you a full day and an angry customer. How many of those do you get a month?" Now any price you name sits next to a number *they* gave you.

Your copy-and-paste question bank

Keep this open during calls. Pick a few; don't run the whole list like a script.

1. "Walk me through a normal day running the shop."
2. "What's the most frustrating part of that?"
3. "Tell me about the last time that went wrong."
4. "What did you do about it?"
5. "How often does that happen?"
6. "What does it cost you when it does — time, money, or stress?"
7. "How are you solving it today?"
8. "What have you already tried? Why didn't it stick?"
9. "If this problem vanished tomorrow, what would change for you?"
10. "Who else deals with this? Could you introduce me?"

Key idea: Curiosity over interrogation. You are not checking boxes; you are following a thread of genuine interest. When you truly want to understand someone's problem, the right questions come naturally — and people can feel the difference.

Key takeaways

- **Open questions** get stories; **closed questions** confirm facts. Lead with open.
- **Leading questions poison your data** — they fish for "yes". Rewrite every one to ask about the real, recent past (The Mom Test).

- Use the **funnel**: wide to find the pain, narrow to get the specific story; layer in SPIN's situation → problem → implication → need-payoff.
- **Silence is a tool**. Ask, then count to five. The deep truth comes after the pause.
- Keep **probes** ready ("tell me more", "what happened next") and use the **5 Whys** to reach the root cause, gently.
- Never ask **double-barreled** or **jargon** questions — one plain question at a time, in their words.
- Talk money by asking about **what they already spend**, not what they "would" pay.

5. Active Listening and Reading the Conversation

Here is good news for a founder who hates "selling": the best sales skill is mostly *listening*. You do not have to be smooth or pushy. You have to make the other person feel heard. That is something a thoughtful, technical person can do really well.

This chapter teaches you how to listen on purpose. We will define every term simply, give you exact lines you can copy, and show you how to spot the signals hiding inside what people say (and don't say).

Key idea: In sales, listening is not the polite thing you do *before* the real work. Listening *is* the work. The person who understands the customer's problem most deeply usually wins.

What "active listening" actually means

Active listening means listening to truly understand the other person, and showing them you understood — not just waiting quietly for your turn to talk. The term was coined in 1957 by psychologist **Carl Rogers** and Richard Farson. Rogers found that when people feel deeply understood, they relax, open up, and get to the real root of their problem.

That is exactly what you want on a sales call. Research on listening shows it does three things: it builds **trust**, it reduces **misunderstandings**, and it gets people to **open up**. A buyer who feels understood tells you what they actually need. A buyer who feels "pitched at" goes quiet and polite — and you learn nothing.

Analogy: Listening is like being a good doctor. A bad doctor hears "my back hurts" and instantly says "take this pill." A good doctor asks where, when, how long, what makes it worse — then diagnoses. Nobody trusts a doctor who prescribes before examining. Nobody trusts a seller who pitches before understanding.

The most important number: talk less than you think

The company Gong analyzed over 100,000 recorded sales calls. The "golden" **talk-to-listen ratio** (how much you talk versus how much you let them talk) for winning calls was about **43% you / 57% them**. The moment a seller talked more than about 65% of the time, win rates dropped.

For a founder who is nervous, this is freeing. Your job is *not* to fill the silence. Your job is to ask a good question and then get out of the way.

Best practice: After the other person stops talking, count "one-one-thousand, two-one-thousand" before you respond. That two-second pause stops you from interrupting and often makes them keep talking — and the second thing they say is usually the more honest one.

```
THE LISTENING LOOP (repeat this all call)

Ask open question  ->  STAY QUIET (2 sec pause)
      ^                  |
      |                  v
      |                  v
Reflect / label  <--  They answer (often twice)
      |
      v
They feel heard  ->  They reveal MORE
```

The core techniques (with exact words you can say)

You only need a handful of moves. Most come from two sources: Carl Rogers' reflective listening, and FBI hostage negotiator **Chris Voss**, whose book *Never Split the Difference* turned these into simple, repeatable tools. Voss calls the overall skill **tactical empathy** — deliberately showing someone you understand their feelings and their situation, so they trust you and keep talking. It is not manipulation; it is connection.

1. Mirroring — repeat their last few words

Mirroring means repeating the last one to three words the person said, in a calm, curious tone, then going silent. It quietly says "tell me more" without asking a real question.

Example:

Customer: "Honestly, our whole ordering process is a mess right now."

You (gently, slight upward tone): "A mess right now...?"

Customer: "Yeah — we take orders over email, things get lost, and customers call angry. Last week we double-printed a job because two people replied to the same thread."

You said three words and got a real, specific, painful story.

2. Labeling — name the feeling

Labeling means naming the emotion or situation you think they are feeling. Voss recommends starting with soft phrases like "It sounds like..." , "It seems like..." , or "It looks like..." — never "I" ("I hear you" makes it about you). Naming a frustration out loud actually calms it down.

Example:

"It sounds like you've been burned by software that promised a lot and delivered nothing."

"It seems like the part that really stings is your customers losing trust, not just the lost time."

Then **stay quiet** and let them confirm or correct you. Either way you learn something.

3. Paraphrasing / reflecting — say it back in your words

Paraphrasing means repeating back what they said, in your own words, to check you understood. This is the Carl Rogers move that validates the person.

Example: "So if I've got this right: orders come in by email, they slip through the cracks, and you end up reprinting jobs at your own cost. Did I get that right?"

4. Summarizing — the big recap

A **summary** is a paraphrase plus a label, covering the whole picture. Voss says a great summary earns the magic words "*That's right*" (very different from a weak "you're right," which often means "now please stop talking"). Use a summary before you move on or propose anything.

Example: "Let me make sure I understand the whole thing. You're handling orders by email, jobs get lost, customers get upset, and it's costing you real money in reprints — and the part that worries you most is your reputation. Is that fair?"

Customer: "That's right." ← *Now you have earned the right to talk.*

5. Tactical empathy as a "package"

You do not pick one technique. You stack them: mirror → they expand → label the feeling → they confirm → summarize. Used together they are far more powerful than any single move.

Getting past vague answers to real specifics

People naturally speak in fluff: "we'd *probably* use that," "we *always* struggle with this," "it'd be *great* to have." Rob Fitzpatrick's **The Mom Test** warns that vague answers and hypotheticals are dangerous — they feel like validation but tell you nothing real. The fix: anchor every vague claim to a *specific past event*.

They say (vague)	You ask (specific)
"We always have trouble with reorders."	"When was the last time that happened? Walk me through it."
"That would be really useful."	"How do you handle that today , before any tool like this?"
"We'd definitely pay for that."	"What are you currently spending on this problem — time or money?"
"It's a big problem."	"Help me understand — what did it cost you the last time?"

Key idea: Opinions about the future are cheap and usually too kind. Facts about the past are gold. Always steer "would / usually / always" back to "the last time this actually happened."

Reading the signals: pain, emotion, and buying signs vs. brush-offs

As you listen, sort what you hear into three buckets.

Pain points and emotion

Listen for the **emotional words**: "frustrating," "embarrassing," "nightmare," "honestly," "I'm sick of." Emotion marks where the real pain lives. When the voice changes —

louder, faster, or suddenly quiet — circle back there. That is the wound, and the wound is where your product earns money.

Real buying signals (lean in)

- They ask about **specifics**: "How would this handle *our* setup?", "Can it import our existing orders?"
- They mention **timing or money**: "We'd need this before our busy season."
- They picture themselves **using it**: "So my staff would just...?"
- They bring in **other people**: "I'd want my partner to see this."

Polite brush-offs (do NOT count as wins)

- "This looks great!" (with no next step)
- "Send me some info." (often a soft no)
- "Let's circle back next quarter." (no real date)
- Lots of compliments, zero questions.

Common mistake: Treating compliments as progress. "I love it!" is not a sale; it is being nice to you. A real signal is a specific question, a date, or a dollar amount — something that costs them a little to say.

On video calls: watch the non-verbal cues

On camera you also get **non-verbal cues** (body language). Leaning in, nodding, and taking their own notes = engaged. Glancing away, flat face, or fast "yep, yep" = you have lost them. When you see disengagement, stop pitching and ask: "I might be off track — what matters most to you here?"

Take notes — and steal their exact words

Write things down during the call (tell them you will: "Mind if I take notes so I don't miss anything?" — it signals respect). The Mom Test gives a crucial reason: capture **exact quotes**, strong emotions, and specific names. Their real words make it "harder to lie to yourself" about whether the problem is real.

Best practice: Keep a column titled "Their exact words." When a customer says "I just want to stop re-typing the same order three times," that is your future homepage headline. Marketing copy written in the customer's own language outperforms anything you invent. Listening today writes your website tomorrow.

The four ways founders fail at listening

1. Waiting to talk

You are not listening; you are reloading. You hear a keyword and start rehearsing your reply. Fix: take notes — it forces your brain to receive, not transmit.

2. Finishing their sentences

You guess where they're going and jump in. You feel smart; they feel unheard, and you miss the real ending. Fix: the 2-second pause.

3. Jumping to the solution

The #1 founder trap. They mention a problem and you launch into "oh, our feature does X!" You stop the diagnosis early and look like a salesperson. Fix: when you feel the urge to pitch, ask one more question instead.

4. Talking too much

Remember the 43/57 number. If you've been talking for more than a minute straight, stop and ask a question.

A full example: reflecting back to unlock the real answer

Example — watch the surface answer turn into the real one:

You: "What's the hardest part of running your print shop right now?"

Customer: "Eh, you know, just the usual busy stuff." (*vague*)

You (mirror): "The usual busy stuff...?"

Customer: "Yeah, mostly chasing customers for files and approvals."

You (label): "It sounds like a lot of your day gets eaten chasing people instead of actually printing."

Customer: "Exactly! I spent four hours yesterday just emailing people for the right logo file." (*now it's specific and emotional*)

You (paraphrase + dig): "Four hours in one day on file chasing. When that happens, what does it cost you — late jobs, unhappy customers?"

Customer: "Both. I missed a deadline last week and gave a 20% refund to keep the client."

You (summary): "So chasing files is eating hours *and* already cost you a refund and a near-lost client. Did I get that right?"

Customer: "That's right. If something fixed just that, I'd buy it tomorrow." ← *a real buying signal, unlocked only because you reflected instead of pitched.*

Notice you never described your product. By listening well, you got the customer to describe the exact problem your product solves — in their words, with a real cost attached. That is what reading the conversation looks like.

Key takeaways

- **Listening is the skill.** Feeling understood (Carl Rogers) builds trust and makes people open up — perfect for a founder who dislikes "selling."
- **Aim for ~43% you / 57% them.** Ask a question, then pause two seconds and let them keep talking.
- **Stack the techniques:** mirror (repeat 1–3 words) → label ("It sounds like...") → paraphrase → summarize until you earn "That's right."
- **Kill vague answers** by anchoring to the last real event: "When did that last happen? What did it cost?" (The Mom Test).
- **Sort signals:** specific questions, dates, and dollar amounts are real; compliments and "send me info" are usually polite brush-offs.
- **Capture their exact words** — they become your marketing copy later.
- **Beware the four failures:** waiting to talk, finishing sentences, jumping to the solution, and talking too much.

6. Running a Great Discovery Call, Start to Finish

A **discovery call** is your first real conversation with a potential customer. "Discovery" means you are trying to *discover* their situation: what they do, what hurts, and whether you can help. A **prospect** is a person or company who might buy from you.

Here is the most freeing thing to know before your first call: a discovery call is not a pitch. You are not on stage selling. You are a curious doctor asking where it hurts. For a technical founder who hates "selling," this is great news. You already know how to ask good questions and listen. That is 90% of the job.

Key idea: A discovery call is a structured conversation to understand the prospect's world. You should be listening about 70% of the time and talking about 30%. The person who asks the questions is the one in control.

Analogy: Think of a good doctor. They don't walk in and say "Here, take this pill, it's amazing." They ask: "What brings you in? When did it start? How bad is it? What have you tried?" Only after they understand do they suggest treatment. A bad salesperson hands you the pill before the questions. A good one earns the right to suggest it.

The shape of the call (a 30-minute map)

Most discovery calls are booked for 30 minutes. Keep it to 30 unless both sides are clearly engaged and want more. Here is a simple time-box you can reuse every time.

30-MINUTE DISCOVERY CALL

0-3 min	OPENING	Rapport + agenda + permission
3-22 min	MIDDLE	Discovery questions (the real work) Situation -> Problem -> Impact -> Tried
22-26 min	YOU TALK	A little about your product (only now)
26-30 min	CLOSING	Summarize + confirm a concrete next step

After: notes -> CRM -> follow-up email within 24 hrs

Before the call: 15 minutes of prep

You do not need to research for an hour. You need three things.

1. **Know the person and company.** Look at their website and the person's LinkedIn profile (a professional profile page). Note what the company does, how big it is, and the person's role. This lets you skip dumb questions and tailor your questions.

2. **Set ONE clear goal for the call.** Not "close the deal." A realistic goal is: *"Understand their biggest problem and decide together if a next step makes sense."* One goal keeps you calm.
3. **Write your agenda and your questions.** A short list of 10-12 questions on a sheet you can glance at. Top sales reps ask roughly 11-15 thoughtful questions per call, mostly open-ended ones.

Best practice: Aim for an 80/20 question mix: about 80% **open questions** (ones that need a real answer, like "Walk me through how you do this today") and 20% **closed questions** (yes/no, like "Are you on a deadline?"). Open questions get people talking; that is where the gold is.

The opening: first 3 minutes

The opening does three jobs: build a little warmth (**rappport**), set the agenda, and get permission. This idea of agreeing the plan up front comes from the **Sandler** sales system, which calls it an **up-front contract** — a quick verbal agreement on the purpose, the time, and the possible outcomes.

Example — opening script (copy this):

"Hi Sam, thanks so much for making the time. How's your week going?" (*let them answer, 20 seconds, be human*)

"So here's what I was thinking for the next 30 minutes. Mostly I'd love to understand how your team handles [their area] today and where it gets painful. I'll ask a bunch of questions. If it sounds like we might be a fit, I'll show you a little of what we do and we can figure out a next step. If it's not a fit, that's totally fine too — I'll tell you honestly. Does that work for you?"

"And just so I respect your time — we're good for 30 minutes, right?"

Notice three quiet moves in that script. You said it is about *understanding*, not *pitching*. You gave them permission to say no — which lowers their guard, because they no longer feel "sold to." And you confirmed the time, so nobody is anxious about the clock.

Common mistake: Diving straight into your product because you're nervous. "So let me tell you what we built..." This makes the prospect a passive listener and teaches you nothing. If you only remember one rule: in the first half of the call, do not pitch.

The middle: discovery questions in the right order

This is the heart of the call. The cleanest framework here is **SPIN Selling**, created by Neil Rackham after studying 35,000 sales calls. SPIN is four kinds of questions, asked in order. You move from the calm outside of the problem to its painful center.

S — Situation (where are you now?)

Understand how they do things today. Keep these short; you researched already, so don't over-ask.
"Walk me through how your team handles [task] right now."

P — Problem (what's broken?)

Find the pain. *"What's the most frustrating part of that process?" "Where does it tend to break down?"*

I — Implication (what does that cost you?)

This is the most powerful and most-skipped type. You help them feel the size of the problem. *"When that happens, what's the knock-on effect? How much time does that eat per week? What does that cost you?"*

N — Need-payoff (what would solving it unlock?)

Let *them* say the value out loud. *"If that problem just disappeared, what would that mean for the team?"* When they describe the benefit themselves, they sell themselves.

There is one more category that is pure gold for early-stage founders, from **Rob Fitzpatrick's book "The Mom Test."** The book's lesson: people lie to be nice (even your mom would say your idea is "great"). So don't ask about the future or about opinions. Ask about the *past* and about real behavior. Facts, not flattery.

Best practice (The Mom Test): Instead of "Would you use this?" ask about what they actually did.

Powerful real-history questions:

- "Tell me about the last time you ran into [problem]."
- "What's the hardest part about dealing with that today?"
- "How are you solving it right now? What have you tried already?"
- "How much does that cost you, in time or money?"

"How much do you already spend on this?" tells you more than "Would you pay for this?" ever will.

Example — a discovery exchange flowing through the order:

You (Situation): "Walk me through how you produce customer quotes today."

Them: "Honestly it's a spreadsheet, and whoever's free does it."

You (Problem): "Where does that tend to go wrong?"

Them: "People use old pricing. We've sent wrong quotes before."

You (Implication): "When a wrong quote goes out, what happens next?"

Them: "We eat the loss, or we look sloppy to the client."

You (Implication, going deeper): "Roughly how often, and what does a bad one cost you?"

Them: "Maybe twice a month. Could be a few hundred dollars each, plus the trust hit."

You (Need-payoff): "If quotes were always right the first time, what would that change for you?"

Them: "We'd look way more professional, and I'd stop losing sleep over it."

See what happened? You did almost no talking, and the prospect just told you their pain, how often it bites, what it costs, and the dream outcome. That last answer is the exact language you'll repeat back

later — and put in your follow-up email.

Key idea: "Uncovering pain" is not enough — you must uncover the cost of the pain. A problem with no cost attached is a problem nobody pays to fix. The Implication questions are what turn "mild annoyance" into "we need to fix this."

Listening is a skill, not a pause

While they talk, do three things. **Don't interrupt** — count to two after they stop, they often add the best part. **Echo back** what you heard: "So if I've got it right, the real cost is the trust hit with clients — is that fair?" This proves you listened and lets them correct you. And **ask "why" / "tell me more"** to go one layer deeper.

When (and how little) to talk about your product

Only after you understand the pain — usually around minute 22 — earn the right to talk. And keep it short. Connect what you say *directly* to the words they used.

Example — the tiny pitch (tied to their pain):

"Based on what you said — wrong pricing on quotes, twice a month, plus the trust hit — here's the one thing I'd show you. Our quoting always pulls live, current pricing, so a wrong quote basically can't go out. Can I show you that one piece for two minutes?"

Common mistake: The "feature dump" — listing all 20 things your product does. The prospect told you about ONE pain. Speak to that one. Save the rest. A focused two-minute answer beats a twenty-minute tour every time.

Closing the call: the last 4 minutes

A call with no clear next step is a wasted call. Closing has three parts: **summarize, confirm fit, and lock a concrete next step** — a real date on a calendar, not "I'll follow up sometime."

Example — closing script (copy this):

"Let me play back what I heard, make sure I've got it. Today quoting is manual, wrong prices slip out about twice a month, it costs you money and some client trust, and ideally you'd never sweat a quote again. Did I miss anything?" (*let them confirm or fix*)

"Honestly, this sounds like a strong fit. Here's what I'd suggest as a next step: let me set up a 30-minute demo where I show your exact quoting flow, working the way you'd want. How's Thursday at 10, or would Friday morning be better?"

"Great — I'll send a calendar invite and a quick recap email today so we're on the same page."

Offering two specific times ("Thursday at 10 or Friday morning?") is far better than "What works for you?" — it makes saying yes easy and gets a real slot booked.

Doing it on Zoom (remote specifics)

- **Turn your camera on** and ask them to. Faces build trust that audio alone can't.
- **Test your setup** 5 minutes early: mic, lighting, internet. A frozen founder looks unreliable.
- **Don't screen-share too early.** A shared screen pulls everyone into "demo mode" and kills discovery. Keep it camera-only until your tiny pitch.
- **Take light notes, but keep eye contact.** Glancing down constantly reads as distracted. Better: ask permission to record so you can stay present ("Mind if I record this just for my notes?").

After the call: notes, CRM, follow-up

The call isn't done when you hang up. Spend 10 minutes right away, while it's fresh.

1. **Write your notes immediately.** Capture their words, especially pain and cost. Their exact phrases ("stop losing sleep over it") are sales gold — reuse them.
2. **Log it in your CRM.** A **CRM** (Customer Relationship Management tool — even a spreadsheet works to start) is where you track every prospect. A good note answers: What was discussed? What do they need? Where are we? What happens next, who owns it, by when?
3. **Send a follow-up email within 24 hours.** Keep it to: what we discussed, what we agreed, and the next step with the date. This proves you listened and creates a shared record.

Example — follow-up email:

"Hi Sam — great talking today. To recap: wrong pricing slips into quotes about twice a month, costing money and some client trust, and you'd love to never worry about a quote again. I think we can fix exactly that. As agreed, I've sent an invite for a tailored demo Thursday at 10. Anything you'd especially want me to focus on? Talk soon — [Name]"

Key takeaways

- A discovery call is about **understanding, not pitching** — listen ~70%, talk ~30%, and ask 11-15 mostly open questions.
- Prep lightly but always: research the person, set **one goal**, and bring a written question list.
- Open with rapport + agenda + permission (the Sandler **up-front contract**) so the prospect relaxes.
- Run questions in SPIN order — **Situation** → **Problem** → **Implication** → **Need-payoff** — and don't skip Implication: pain only matters once its **cost** is clear.
- Use **The Mom Test**: ask about past behavior and real spending, not opinions or "would you" hypotheticals.
- Talk about your product late, briefly, and tied to *their exact pain* — never a feature dump.

- Always close on a **concrete next step with a date**, then within 24 hours write notes, update your CRM, and send a recap email.

7. Sales Discovery Frameworks: SPIN, BANT, MEDDIC and Friends

Let's start with a worry you might have. "Frameworks" sounds like a cold, salesy word. You picture someone reading a script at you. That is *not* what this chapter is about. A sales framework is just a **list of things worth finding out** on a call, in a sensible order. Think of it as a checklist a doctor keeps in their head, not a speech.

First, two plain-English definitions you'll need all chapter:

Discovery

The part of a conversation where you *learn* about the other person's situation and problems — before you talk about your product. Most of selling is discovery.

Qualification

Deciding whether this person is actually a good fit to buy — so you don't waste weeks chasing someone who was never going to say yes.

Key idea: Discovery frameworks help you *understand the problem*. Qualification frameworks help you *decide if the deal is real*. You need both, but discovery comes first. A confused founder pitches; a calm founder asks questions.

Analogy: A framework is like a recipe's ingredient list. It tells you what you need in the dish — flour, eggs, sugar. It does *not* tell you the exact words to say while cooking. You still cook in your own voice. Reading a recipe out loud to a dinner guest would be weird. So would reciting a framework at a customer.

The golden rule before any framework: talk less

Gong, a company that records and analyzes huge numbers of real sales calls, found that on discovery calls the best-performing reps talk about **46% of the time** and listen 54%. The worst performers talk around 72% of the time. So the single biggest skill is closing your own mouth. Every framework below is really just a way to spend your listening time well.

Best practice: Aim to talk less than half the time on a discovery call. If you've been speaking for more than 30 seconds, stop and ask a question.

SPIN Selling — the discovery framework to learn first

SPIN comes from **Neil Rackham**, who studied over 35,000 real sales calls over 12 years and wrote the book *SPIN Selling* (1988). It is still the best starting point for a founder because it's built entirely on

asking questions in a smart order. SPIN is four *types* of question:

S — Situation

Facts about how things work today. (Background.)

P — Problem

What's frustrating, broken, or hard right now.

I — Implication

What that problem *costs* them — in money, time, or stress. This makes the pain feel bigger.

N — Need-payoff

What life would look like if the problem were solved. You let *them* describe the value.

The genius is the order: you move from harmless facts, to a sore spot, to *why the sore spot matters*, to *the buyer talking themselves into wanting a fix*. Rackham's research showed the I and N questions are what actually move bigger deals — most beginners skip them.

Common mistake: Spending the whole call on Situation questions ("How big is your team? What tools do you use?"). Too many of these bore the buyer and feel like an interrogation. Ask only enough facts to get to the real Problem questions.

Here are copy-able example questions for each letter. Steal these:

Type	Example questions you can say out loud
Situation	"Walk me through how your team handles this today." · "What tools are you using for that right now?"
Problem	"Where does that process tend to break down?" · "What's the most frustrating part of doing it that way?"
Implication	"When that happens, what does it cost you — in hours or in lost sales?" · "How does that affect the rest of your team?" · "If nothing changes, where does this leave you in six months?"
Need-payoff	"If you could fix that, what would that be worth to you?" · "How would your week look different if this just worked?"

Worked example: SPIN on a real B2B SaaS call

Imagine you sell software that auto-generates print-ready PDFs (very close to home for a print-SaaS founder). You're talking to the owner of a small print shop.

Example:

You (Situation): "How do your customers send you their artwork right now?"

Owner: "They email me files, and honestly half of them are the wrong size or low resolution."

You (Problem): "What happens when a file comes in wrong?"

Owner: "I email them back, we go back and forth, sometimes three or four times."

You (Implication): "Roughly how many hours a week does that back-and-forth eat up? And do you ever lose the order because of it?"

Owner: "Easily six or seven hours. And yeah — maybe two or three jobs a month just walk away because it's too slow."

You (Implication, going deeper): "If each of those jobs is worth, say, \$200, that's a few hundred dollars a month plus a full workday gone. Is that about right?"

Owner: "...when you put it like that, it's worse than I thought."

You (Need-payoff): "If customers could only ever upload a file that was already print-ready — no wrong sizes, no back-and-forth — what would that be worth to you?"

Owner: "Honestly? That would change my whole week. How does your thing do that?"

Notice: the owner asked *you* to pitch. That's the goal. You never pushed. The questions did the work.

Qualification frameworks — is this deal even real?

Once you understand the problem, you check whether they can actually buy. Three names you'll hear:

BANT — the simple old-school checklist

Created by **IBM in the 1950s**. Four things to confirm:

- **Budget** — can they afford it / is money set aside?
- **Authority** — is this person able to say yes, or do they need a boss?
- **Need** — is the problem real and worth solving?
- **Timeline** — when do they want this fixed?

BANT is easy to remember and fine for small, simple sales. But it was built for a world with one decision-maker and a fixed budget. Today a B2B deal can involve 6–10 people, so don't treat it as a rigid "fail one, reject them" test. Use it as gentle questions: "Have you set aside budget for this, or are we still building the case?" · "Besides you, who else would weigh in on a decision like this?"

MEDDIC / MEDDPICC — for bigger, complex deals

MEDDIC was created inside the company **PTC in 1996**. It's a deeper checklist for expensive deals with many stakeholders. The letters:

- **Metrics** — the numbers that prove value (e.g. "saves 6 hours/week").
- **Economic buyer** — the one person who controls the money.
- **Decision criteria** — what they'll judge the choice on.

- **Decision process** — the steps they'll go through to buy.
- **Identify pain** — the real problem (same idea as SPIN's P and I).
- **Champion** — an insider who wants you to win and will fight for you internally.

MEDDPICC adds two more: **Paper process** (the legal/procurement paperwork that quietly kills deals) and **Competition** (who else they're considering, including doing nothing). Use MEDDIC only when deals get large and slow. For most early founders it's overkill — but knowing "do I have a Champion?" and "who is the Economic buyer?" is genuinely useful even on small deals.

GAP Selling and the Sandler Pain Funnel — two great extras

GAP Selling (from the author **Keenan**) is one simple, powerful idea: find the *gap* between their **current state** (where they are now, and what it costs) and their **future state** (where they want to be). The bigger the gap, the more they want to buy. Your job is to make the gap clear and concrete. SPIN's Implication questions are how you measure that gap.

The **Sandler Pain Funnel** (from **David Sandler**) is a sequence of gently deepening questions that lets the buyer convince *themselves*. Lines you can copy:

Example: "Tell me more about that." → "Can you give me a specific example?" → "How long has this been a problem?" → "What have you already tried to fix it?" → "How much do you think that's costing you?" → "How do you feel about that?" → "Have you given up trying to solve it?"

Putting it together — which framework, when

EARLY in a call -----	LATER in a call -----
SPIN / Pain Funnel (understand problem)	BANT (small deal)
GAP (size the gap)	MEDDIC (big deal)
	Champion + Econ buyer check

Framework	What it's good for	When to use it
SPIN	Asking great questions, uncovering pain	Every discovery call — learn this first
GAP Selling	Making the cost of the problem vivid	When the buyer downplays their pain
Sandler Pain Funnel	Letting buyers talk themselves into change	When you sense real but unspoken frustration
BANT	Quick fit-check on simple deals	Small, fast sales with one decision-maker
MEDDIC / MEDDPICC	Managing big, multi-person deals	High price, 5+ stakeholders, 90+ day cycles

Common mistake: Treating a framework as a script and firing questions in a robotic list while ignoring the answers. The buyer can feel it instantly. The letters are a *memory aid for you*, not a form to fill in. Follow the human in front of you; the framework just keeps you from forgetting something important.

Best practice: Learn *one* framework deeply — make it SPIN — and use the others as a mental checklist after the call: "Did I find the pain? Do I know who controls the budget? How big is the gap?" Gaps in your notes show you what to ask next time.

Key takeaways

- A framework is a **checklist and a lens, not a script** — adapt it, never recite it.
- **Talk less than half the time**; top reps listen 54% of a discovery call (Gong).
- **SPIN** (Situation → Problem → Implication → Need-payoff) is the one to master first — its power is in the Implication and Need-payoff questions most people skip.
- Discovery comes before qualification: understand the problem, *then* check if the deal is real.
- **BANT** for simple deals, **MEDDIC/MEDDPICC** for big complex ones — and always know your **Champion** and **Economic buyer**.
- **GAP Selling** sizes the distance between today's pain and the desired future; a bigger gap means more motivation to buy.
- The **Sandler Pain Funnel** uses gentle, deepening questions so buyers convince themselves — let silence and curiosity do the work.

8. Qualifying: Choosing Who Deserves Your Time

Let's start with a hard truth that will save your startup. You will never have enough time. As a solo technical founder, you are the engineer, the support team, the marketer, and the salesperson. Every hour you spend talking to the wrong person is an hour stolen from building, shipping, and finding the right person.

This chapter is about a single skill: deciding who is worth your time, and saying a polite "no" to everyone else. In sales, this is called **qualifying**. To qualify a person means to figure out whether they are a real, good-fit potential customer before you pour your energy into them.

Key idea: Your scarcest resource is not money. It is your time and attention. Good selling is not about chasing everyone. It is about quickly finding the few people who are a true fit, and gently letting go of the rest.

Why this matters more for you than for anyone else

Big companies have armies of salespeople. They can afford to chase weak leads. You cannot. If you spend three weeks on a deal that was never going to happen, that is three weeks your business may not get back.

There is also a quieter danger. Bad-fit customers do not just waste your time before they buy. They waste it *after* too. They ask for features nobody else wants. They complain. They churn (cancel) quickly. They give you misleading feedback that pulls your product in the wrong direction. One wrong-fit customer can quietly steer your whole roadmap off a cliff.

Analogy: Qualifying is like a doctor doing triage in an emergency room. The doctor cannot treat everyone at once, so they quickly sort patients: who needs help now, who can wait, who is in the wrong building entirely. It feels cold, but it is actually the kindest, most responsible thing to do. Sending someone to the right place fast is a gift, not a rejection.

First, know who you are looking for: the ICP

You cannot judge a "good fit" until you know what good looks like. This is your **Ideal Customer Profile**, usually shortened to **ICP**. An ICP is a short, plain description of the type of customer most likely to buy, stay, and benefit from what you sell.

For a business-to-business product (a product you sell to companies, not individuals), your ICP usually describes a *company*: its size, its industry, how it works. You also describe the *person* inside that company who feels the pain and can say yes. That person is called a **persona**. ICP is the company; persona is the human.

Here is a simple way to write your first ICP. Look at your happiest current users (even if you only have two). Find what they share.

ICP attribute	Example for Print-Flow-360
Type of business	Independent print shop selling online
Size	1 to 15 staff, owner-run
The painful problem	Drowning in manual order & artwork chaos
How they work today	Spreadsheets, email, no real online store
The persona (who buys)	The owner, non-technical, time-starved
Geography / language	English-speaking, online-comfortable

Best practice: Make your first ICP narrow on purpose. "Solo print-shop owners doing manual orders" is far more useful than "small businesses." A narrow ICP makes the next step, qualifying, almost automatic. Companies with a sharp ICP win deals at much higher rates than those who chase everyone.

Qualifying IN versus qualifying OUT

There are two ways to think about a sales conversation. Most beginners only do one of them.

Qualifying in

Looking for reasons this person *is* a great fit. ("They have the exact problem I solve. Wonderful.")

Qualifying out

Actively hunting for reasons this person is *not* a fit, so you can stop fast. ("They have no budget and no urgency. I should let this go.")

Experienced salespeople do both, but they treasure qualifying *out*. There is a well-known piece of advice: in a sales call, act like a goalkeeper, not a striker. A striker tries to force the ball into the goal. A goalkeeper calmly checks every angle to make sure nothing slips past. You are trying to "close the doors", to rule things out, not to force a yes.

Common mistake: Treating disqualifying as failure. It is the opposite. A fast, honest "this isn't right for you" protects your time AND respects theirs. Letting someone slowly realize over two months that your product was never for them is the unkind path. Disqualifying quickly is a kindness to both sides.

The signals: good-fit versus bad-fit

Two famous frameworks help here, and you do not need to memorize them, just understand the spirit.

BANT (used since the 1950s) lists four things to check: **B**udget, **A**uthority, **N**eed, and **T**iming. In plain words: Can they pay? Can they decide? Do they really have the problem? Are they ready soon?

MEDDIC is a heavier framework for big enterprise deals; as a solo founder selling to small businesses, BANT's four simple questions are plenty for now.

Here is what the four signals look like in real life.

Signal	Good-fit (lean in)	Bad-fit (lean out)
Real pain	"I lost an order last week because of this." Specific, recent, costly.	"Yeah, it'd be nice to be more organized someday." Vague.
Budget / willingness	Already pays for tools; asks "how much?" calmly.	"Is there a free version forever?" Flinches at any price.
Authority	Can say yes themselves, or names the one person who can.	"I'd have to run it past a lot of people." (endless committee)
Urgency / timing	"I need this fixed this month."	"Maybe next year, let's stay in touch." (a zombie lead)

Rob Fitzpatrick, in his classic little book *The Mom Test*, gives the sharpest signal of all. He says watch for **commitment**, not compliments. A compliment ("I love this, great idea!") is worthless; it costs the person nothing. Real interest shows up when someone gives up something they value: their **time** (a follow-up meeting), their **reputation** (introducing you to their boss or peers), or their **money**. As Fitzpatrick puts it, a person who talks endlessly about a problem but never acts to solve it is "a *complainer, not a customer.*"

Beware your own "happy ears"

This is the trap that catches almost every founder. You built this product. You desperately want it to work. So your brain hears only the good parts. The salesperson's term for this is **happy ears**: being so eager that you notice every "yes" and tune out every hesitation, doubt, and "but."

Example: A prospect says: *"This looks really cool. We're pretty busy right now, and I'm not totally sure we have the budget, but yeah, neat stuff."*

Happy ears hear: "This looks really cool... yeah!"

Trained ears hear: "We're busy" (no urgency) + "not sure we have budget" (no money) = this is probably not a real deal yet. Two doors are wide open.

Best practice: After every call, write down what they actually *did* or *committed to*, not what they said they felt. "Agreed to a paid pilot next week" is signal. "Said it was awesome" is noise. Facts over feelings.

The vocabulary: lead, prospect, opportunity

You will hear these three words used loosely. They actually mark three stages, and knowing them keeps your head clear.

LEAD (curious)	PROSPECT (qualified fit)	OPPORTUNITY (real deal in motion)
Someone who showed mild interest. Not yet checked.	A lead who matches your ICP and has real interest. Now a two-way talk.	A prospect with a clear next step, a likely value, and a path to closing.

Lead

Anyone who showed a flicker of interest. Unchecked. Could be anyone.

Prospect

A lead you have qualified, they fit your ICP and show genuine intent. You are now in real two-way conversation.

Opportunity

A prospect with a concrete, agreed next step and a real chance of buying soon.

Qualifying is simply the gate between "lead" and "prospect." Most leads should never become prospects, and that is healthy.

A dead-simple scoring checklist

You do not need fancy software. After a first call, score the person 0, 1, or 2 on each line.

1. **Pain:** Do they have the exact problem I solve, and is it costing them? (0 = no / 2 = clearly, recently)
2. **Fit:** Do they match my ICP? (0 = wrong type / 2 = bullseye)
3. **Money:** Can and will they pay? (0 = no budget / 2 = ready to pay)
4. **Authority:** Can this person (or a named person) say yes? (0 = unclear / 2 = yes)
5. **Urgency:** Do they want to act soon? (0 = "someday" / 2 = "this month")

Roughly: **8 to 10** = a real prospect, give them your time. **4 to 7** = nurture lightly, do not chase. **0 to 3** = disqualify, walk away with a smile. Adjust the cutoffs to your own experience over time.

How to gracefully walk away

Disqualifying does not mean being rude or ghosting. The best move is honest, warm, and useful. You can even win goodwill and referrals by being the founder who told the truth.

Example (ending a mismatched call politely):

"Thanks for being so open with me. Honestly, based on what you've described, I don't think Print-Flow-360 is the right fit for you right now, your volume is low and you're happy with your current process. I'd rather tell you that than have you pay for something you won't get value from."

Then add a parting gift:

"If it helps, a simpler free tool like [X] might cover what you need today. And if your order volume grows or the manual work starts hurting, send me a note, I'm happy to revisit it then."

Notice the three moves: thank them, state plainly why it is not a fit, and leave them better off (a tip, a door left open). Nobody walks away feeling rejected. Many will remember you fondly and refer someone who *is* a fit.

Common mistake: Keeping a "zombie lead" alive out of politeness or hope, the person who always says "still interested!" but never moves. Each follow-up costs you time and false hope. It is kinder and smarter to ask directly: *"Should we keep talking, or is this not the right time for you?"* Let them off the hook, and free yourself.

Key takeaways

- Your time is your scarcest asset; qualifying protects it. Chasing bad-fit prospects quietly kills startups.
- Define a narrow Ideal Customer Profile (ICP) first, you cannot judge "fit" without knowing what good looks like.
- Hunt for reasons to qualify *out*, not just in. Be the goalkeeper closing doors, not the striker forcing a yes.
- Check the four BANT signals, real pain, budget, authority, urgency, and trust commitment over compliments (The Mom Test).
- Beware "happy ears": record what people *do* and commit to, not what they say they feel.
- Know the ladder, lead to prospect to opportunity; most leads should never advance, and that is healthy.
- Disqualify fast and warmly. A clear, kind "not a fit" respects both sides and often earns referrals.

9. The Demo: Show Value Without Overselling

A **demo** (short for "demonstration") is when you show your product to a potential customer. For a technical founder, this is the part that feels safe. You built the thing. You know every button. So it is tempting to open the app and start clicking.

That instinct is exactly the trap. The most common bad demo is a **feature dump** — clicking through every feature you are proud of, in the order they appear on the screen, while the prospect quietly checks their email. A good demo is the opposite. It is short, it is about *them*, and it is a conversation, not a tour.

Key idea: A demo is not a tour of your software. It is proof that the specific pain the person just told you about will go away. Everything else is noise — and noise hides the signal.

The golden rule: discovery before demo (never demo blind)

"**Discovery**" means the questions you ask to learn the person's real problem before you show anything (Chapter 8 was all about this). "Demo blind" means demoing before you have done that — you have no idea what they care about, so you show everything and hope something sticks.

Sales coaches are blunt about this. Peter Cohan, author of the classic book *Great Demo!*, and the modern presales community both repeat the same line: **never demo blind**. If a prospect says "just show me the product," the move is a gentle redirect, not obedience.

Example — redirecting "just show me":

Prospect: "Can you just walk me through the product?"

You: "Happy to — and I'll be quick. So I show you the parts that actually matter to *you* and don't waste your time on the rest, can I ask two fast questions about how you handle [their job] today?"

Analogy: A good doctor doesn't hand you medicine the second you walk in. They ask where it hurts first. Prescribing before diagnosing is malpractice — in medicine and in demos. Discovery is your diagnosis.

Tailor the demo to the pains you actually heard

Discovery gives you a short list of what this person is bleeding from. Your demo should show *those exact things* — and ideally nothing else. If they told you "approvals take forever and my reports are a mess," you show approvals and reports, in depth. You do not show the eight other features you love.

Best practice: Pick the **2–3 capabilities** that map to the pains they named. Show those well. A deep demo of two things that matter beats a shallow tour of ten things that don't.

A simple, powerful trick: use *their* world inside the demo. Their company name. Their kind of data. The exact workflow they described. When a prospect sees their own situation on screen, they stop watching a product and start imagining their life with it.

Show the destination before the journey

Peter Cohan's most famous principle is "**Do the Last Thing First.**" Most demos build up slowly — setup, then steps, then finally the payoff. Cohan flips it: show the **finished, impressive result first** (the "destination"), get the "wow," *then* show how easy it was to get there (the "journey").

Why? Because if people see the payoff first, they actually care about the steps. If you make them sit through the steps first, they tune out before the payoff arrives.

```
FEATURE-DUMP ORDER (weak):
  step 1 -> step 2 -> step 3 -> ... -> [maybe a payoff?]
      (prospect tunes out around here ^)

DESTINATION-FIRST ORDER (strong):
  [THE WOW RESULT] -> "and here's how simple that was"
      ^ they lean in           ^ now they care
```

Example — destination first:

"Here's the finished print-ready order, with the proof already approved and the artwork queued to production. That's the end state. Now let me show you — it took your customer about 40 seconds to get there. Watch."

Tell–Show–Tell: the structure for each thing you show

"**Tell–Show–Tell**" is a demo structure taught by 2Win! Global and many sales-engineering teams. For each capability, you do three small steps:

1. **Tell** — say the value first: "You mentioned approvals are slow. Here's how this fixes that."
2. **Show** — actually do it on screen, quickly.
3. **Tell** — reinforce what they just saw, in value terms: "So that approval that took three emails just happened in one click."

Some teach it as **Need–Show–Value** — same idea, sharper labels. State the *need*, show the feature, name the *value*. The structure forces you to wrap every feature in a reason to care.

Demo outcomes, not features — the "so what?" test

A **feature** is what the product *does* ("it auto-saves every 30 seconds"). An **outcome** (or value) is what that *means for the person* ("you never lose work, even if your browser crashes mid-order"). Customers buy outcomes. They tolerate features.

Here is the cheapest quality check in all of selling. After every sentence in your demo, silently ask: **"So what?"** If you can't answer in terms of *their* pain, cut the sentence.

Feature dump (weak)	Outcome-led (strong)
"It has real-time syncing."	"Your team always sees the same order status, so nobody prints the wrong version."
"We support role-based permissions."	"Your junior staff can take orders but can't change pricing — so no accidental discounts."
"There's a dashboard with 12 widgets."	"You said month-end reporting eats a day. This is that day, on one screen."

Keep it short, and make it a dialogue

A demo should feel like a conversation, not a TED talk. If you talk for ten minutes straight, you have lost the room. Build in **check-ins** — small questions that keep them talking and tell you if you're on target.

Best practice: Stop and check in roughly every 90 seconds. Copy-able check-in lines:

- "Is that how you'd want it to work?"
- "Does this look like the problem you described?"
- "Want me to go deeper here, or move on?"
- "How does your current tool handle this part?"

Common mistake: Treating silence as a green light to keep clicking. Silence in a demo usually means confusion or boredom, not agreement. When you go quiet and ask, you find out which — and you put them back in the driver's seat.

Let them drive — and the difference between a demo and a trial

People believe what they touch. Where it's safe to do so, hand over control: "Here, you try adding a product — I'll guide you." This is far more convincing than watching you, because they feel how easy (or hard) it really is.

Two related but different things:

Demo

You (or you together) show the product live, usually in one session, focused on their pains.

Trial

They use the product themselves over days or weeks, in their own world. A trial is powerful but risky if they're left alone with no guidance — most people poke around, get stuck, and quietly give up. If

you offer a trial, give them a tiny "first win" goal and check in. A demo should usually come *before* a trial, so they know what success looks like.

Handling "Can it do X?" — honestly, including saying no

Prospects will ask about features you don't have. The instinct is to fudge it ("um, sort of, kind of, we're working on it"). Don't. Vague answers read as a "no" wrapped in fear, and they cost you trust.

Example — three honest answers:

Yes: "Yes — let me show you." (Then show it. Never claim it without proof.)

Not yet: "No, not today. It's on our roadmap for next quarter. Is that a must-have for you, or a nice-to-have?" (Their answer is gold — it tells you if this is a dealbreaker.)

Never / not us: "No, that's not what we're built for — tools like [X] do that better. We're focused on [your core value]." (Saying no to the wrong fit builds enormous trust.)

Best practice: When you say "not yet," turn it into discovery: "Out of curiosity, what would you use that for?" You may learn it's not actually needed — or find your next feature.

Why overselling quietly destroys you later

Overselling — promising more than the product really does — feels like winning the deal. It is actually borrowing against your future. The customer signs up expecting the thing you implied, doesn't find it, feels lied to, and leaves. Research on customer trust is stark: a single broken promise drives churn in a large share of cases, and most consumers will switch after just one bad experience.

For a solo founder this is doubly dangerous. A churned, angry customer doesn't just leave — they tell others, leave a bad review, and ask for a refund. You spent effort to win a customer who now *costs* you. The honest "no" you avoided in the demo would have been free.

Key idea: Under-promise and over-deliver. The customer you keep is worth ten you oversold and lost. Confidence in sales isn't claiming everything — it's being calm enough to say "we don't do that," because you trust the value you *do* deliver.

When something breaks live (it will)

Live demos crash, lag, or show a bug. As a technical founder, you might panic. Don't — how you handle it teaches the prospect more than the bug does. Stay calm, name it plainly, move on.

Example — recovering from a live bug:

"Ha — there's a glitch on this screen, ignore that. It's the kind of thing I fix same-day, which is honestly one perk of working with a founder directly. Let me show you the part that matters." (Then continue. Don't over-apologize or disappear into debugging.)

Common mistake: Spending three minutes trying to fix a bug live while the prospect watches you sweat. Acknowledge it, skip it, follow up later: "I'll send you that working in a quick recording." The deal is in the conversation, not the broken pixel.

Before / after: the same product, two demos

Feature-dump version (weak):

"So this is the dashboard. Up here are 12 widgets. This is settings — lots of options. Here's the product catalog, you can add unlimited products, tag them, bulk-edit. Over here is the design studio, it uses Fabric.js, super powerful. And we have an API, webhooks, role permissions, multi-currency..."

(Prospect: glazed over. "Looks... comprehensive. We'll think about it.")

Value-led version (strong):

"You said two things hurt: customers email you back and forth about proofs, and you lose a day every month on reports. Let me show you both.

First — here's a finished, customer-approved proof, no emails needed. [shows result] That whole back-and-forth? Gone. Your customer did it in under a minute. Want to try clicking approve yourself?

Second — your month-end report. [shows it] That's the day you described, on one screen. Is this the number you usually hand-build in a spreadsheet?"

(Prospect, leaning in: "Wait — can it also handle bulk orders?" Now you're in a conversation.)

Key takeaways

- **Never demo blind.** Discovery first — diagnose before you prescribe; tailor the demo to the 2–3 pains they actually named.
- **Show the destination first** ("do the last thing first"), then the journey — the wow earns their attention for the how.
- **Use Tell–Show–Tell** (or Need–Show–Value) and the "so what?" test, so every feature is wrapped in an outcome they care about.
- **Make it a short dialogue**, not a monologue — check in every ~90 seconds and let them drive when you can.
- **Answer "can it do X?" honestly**, including "not yet" and "that's not us" — a clean no builds more trust than a fuzzy yes.
- **Don't oversell.** One broken promise drives churn and refunds; under-promise, over-deliver, and let kept customers compound.
- **When it breaks live, stay calm**, name it, skip it, follow up — your composure sells more than the feature would have.

10. Handling Objections With Honesty

Let's start by calming a fear. When a customer pushes back — "that's expensive," "I need to think about it," "we already use something else" — most founders feel a small jolt of panic. Your brain hears "no." Your stomach drops. You either go quiet or start talking too fast to defend yourself.

Here is the truth that changes everything: **an objection is usually not a no**. It is a question wearing a frown. It is the customer saying, "I'm interested enough to keep talking, but something is in my way. Help me move it."

Key idea: An objection is a request for more information and a sign of engagement. People who are truly uninterested don't object — they politely disappear. Someone who objects is still in the room with you.

This chapter gives you a calm, repeatable method to handle any objection — without arguing, without lying, and without becoming someone you don't like.

First, fix your mindset: welcome objections

An *objection* is any reason the customer gives for not moving forward right now. Beginners treat objections as attacks. Pros treat them as gifts, because:

- An unspoken doubt kills the deal silently. A *spoken* doubt is one you can actually address.
- Objections tell you what the customer truly cares about. "Is it secure?" means security matters to them. Now you know.
- The customer is doing your homework for you — pointing at the exact thing standing between you and "yes."

Analogy: An objection is like a patient telling a doctor "it hurts when I press here." That's not bad news — that's the most useful sentence in the whole visit. A doctor who got defensive ("Well, it shouldn't hurt!") would be a terrible doctor. Your job is to gently press where it hurts and understand why.

The five-step method: pause, acknowledge, clarify, respond, confirm

This is built on a widely taught sales framework called **LAARC** — Listen, Acknowledge, Assess, Respond, Confirm. I've reshaped it for a nervous beginner. Memorize these five moves and you can handle anything.

OBJECTION

- |
1. PAUSE breathe, don't react
 v
 2. ACKNOWLEDGE "that's fair", show you heard them
 v
 3. CLARIFY ask a question, find the REAL concern
 v
 4. RESPOND answer the real concern, honestly
 v
 5. CONFIRM "does that address it?" check you landed

1. Pause

Wait two seconds. Seriously. The silence feels long to you and normal to them. Pausing stops you from getting defensive and signals you're taking them seriously, not firing back a rehearsed line.

2. Acknowledge (never argue)

Show you heard them before you say anything else. This earns trust in the first few seconds. You are not agreeing they're *right* — you're agreeing their concern is *reasonable*.

- "That's a fair question."
- "I completely understand — that's an important thing to get right."
- "Makes sense. A lot of people ask exactly that."

3. Clarify — this is the step beginners skip

Most objections are the *surface* of a deeper concern. "Too expensive" might mean "I don't see the value," or "the budget sits with someone else," or "I had a bad experience last time." If you answer the surface words, you answer the wrong question. So ask:

- "Can you help me understand what specifically feels expensive — is it the total, or how it compares to something?"
- "When you say you need to think about it, what's the main thing on your mind?"
- "Just so I answer the right thing — what's driving that concern?"

Best practice: Paraphrase what you heard before responding: "So if I've got it right, the worry is X — is that fair?" This prevents you from solving a problem they don't have, and it makes them feel genuinely heard.

4. Respond — honestly, to the real concern

Now, and only now, you answer. Keep it short. Tie it to what they care about. We'll cover specific responses below.

5. Confirm

Don't assume you cleared it. Check: "Does that address what you were worried about?" or "How does that sit with you?" If it landed, you move forward. If it didn't, you loop back to clarify. Confirming stops a fake "yes" that quietly dies later.

True objection vs. brush-off (a stall)

You must learn to tell these apart, because they need different moves.

A true objection

A real, specific concern from someone who sees value: "I like it, but I'm worried it won't integrate with our printer." You handle these with the five steps.

A brush-off / stall

A polite escape hatch: "Send me some info," "let me think about it," "circle back next quarter." Often it's just an easier way of saying "not now" or "no" without the awkwardness.

In *The Mom Test*, Rob Fitzpatrick (a must-read book for technical founders learning to talk to customers) warns that founders get fooled by exactly this — a compliment followed by a stall, like "Looks great, send me the details!" It feels positive. It usually means nothing. Fitzpatrick's fix is to chase **commitment**, not kindness. Real interest costs the customer something: time, a clear next step, an intro, or money.

Common mistake: Treating "send me info" as a win and emailing a brochure into the void. That's how deals die quietly. Test whether it's real by asking for a small commitment instead.

Example — testing a stall:

Them: "This looks interesting. Send me some info and I'll take a look."

You: "Happy to. Info-by-email tends to get buried, though — would it be more useful if I set up 20 minutes next week to walk through the two parts that matter for your shop? If next week's too soon, that probably tells us the timing isn't right, and that's totally okay."

If they grab the meeting, it was real interest. If they dodge, you've saved yourself weeks of false hope — honestly and without pressure.

Common objections and honest responses

Objection	What it often really means	Honest first move
"Too expensive"	"I don't yet see the value" or "wrong budget pot"	Clarify which, then reframe price vs. value & cost of doing nothing
"No time"	"This isn't a priority yet"	Ask what's eating the time; show how you give time back
"We already use X"	"Convince me switching is worth the pain"	Respect X; ask what's missing; don't trash a tool they chose
"Send me info"	Polite stall	Offer a small live next step instead (see above)
"Need to think about it"	An unspoken worry remains	Ask what specifically they want to weigh
"Talk to my team"	Real (shared decision) or a stall	Offer to join that conversation; arm them to explain it

Example dialogue 1 — "It's too expensive"

Example:

Them: "Honestly, it's more than I wanted to spend."

You (acknowledge): "Totally fair — price matters and you should push on it."

You (clarify): "Can I ask — is it that the total's above budget, or that you're not yet sure it's worth this much?"

Them: "I'm not sure it's worth it for us."

You (respond, value + cost of inaction): "That's the right question. Right now your team re-keys every order by hand — you mentioned about ten hours a week. This removes most of that. So the question isn't really \$X a month, it's whether getting those hours back is worth \$X. If it's not, I'd honestly tell you not to buy."

You (confirm): "Does looking at it that way change the picture, or is the total still the wall?"

Notice: you reframed *price* (what they pay) as *value* (what they get) and named the *cost of inaction* (the ten hours bleeding away now). And you gave them a real "out" — that honesty is what makes the value claim believable.

Example dialogue 2 — "We already use X"

Example:

Them: "We're already on a competitor's tool."

You (acknowledge, no trash-talk): "Good — they're solid, and it's smart you've already got something running."

You (clarify): "If you could wave a wand and fix one thing about it, what would it be?"

Them: "Honestly, their support takes days."

You (respond): "That's the gap a lot of folks come to us for — you get a same-day reply from someone who actually knows print. I'm not going to pretend everything else is better; in some areas they're great. But on support, that's our whole thing."

You (confirm): "Is slow support a big enough pain to be worth a closer look?"

Example dialogue 3 — "I need to think about it"

Example:

Them: "Let me think about it and get back to you."

You (acknowledge): "Of course — this shouldn't be a snap decision."

You (clarify): "So I can be useful while you do — what's the main thing you'll be weighing? Is it the price, whether your team will adopt it, or something else?"

Them: "Mostly whether my staff will actually use it."

You (respond): "Got it — that's the real question, not the software. Want me to set up a 15-minute walkthrough for the two people who'd use it daily? If they push back, you'll have your answer fast."

You (confirm): "Would that help you decide, or is there another worry underneath it?"

The honesty line: helping vs. manipulating

Sandler, a respected sales methodology, puts it plainly: selling should never be a game of manipulation — its purpose is to serve the buyer's needs. That's your compass. The five-step method works because it uncovers a real problem and matches a real solution. The instant you twist it into "make them say yes no matter what," you've crossed into manipulation — and with a technical founder's reputation, that's a terrible trade.

Common mistake: Inventing a feature, a fake deadline ("price goes up tomorrow" when it doesn't), or a made-up testimonial to beat an objection. You might win the deal and lose the customer the moment reality lands. Overpromising is just a slow no.

Best practice: When you don't have an answer, say so: "We don't do that yet — it's not on our roadmap. If that's a dealbreaker, I'd rather tell you now." Founders are stunned by how much trust this buys. Honesty about a weakness makes every strength you claim believable.

And never argue. The moment you debate a customer, even if you "win," you lose — nobody buys from someone who just made them feel wrong. Stay curious, not defensive. The customer is not the enemy;

the unsolved problem is.

Key takeaways

- An objection is engagement, not rejection — it's a request for information that tells you exactly what stands between you and "yes."
- Use the five steps every time: **pause, acknowledge, clarify, respond, confirm**. The clarify step is the one beginners skip and the one that matters most.
- Most objections are a surface for a deeper concern — ask a question to find the real one before you answer.
- Learn to spot a brush-off ("send me info," "let me think") and test it by asking for a small, real commitment, as *The Mom Test* advises.
- For "too expensive," reframe price as value and name the cost of doing nothing — and be willing to say "then don't buy."
- Never argue, never trash a competitor, never get defensive — stay curious; the problem is the enemy, not the person.
- Honesty is the strategy: never fabricate or overpromise to win an objection. Serving the buyer beats manipulating them, every time.

11. Hearing "No": Turning Rejection Into Learning

If you are a founder who finds selling uncomfortable, this is probably the chapter you have been quietly dreading. The "no." The polite email that says they went another way. The call that just goes silent. It stings. Let's deal with that honestly, and then let's flip it into the most useful tool you have.

Here is the truth that changes everything: in your early days, a **"no" is data, not damage**. Each one is a tiny, free lesson about your product, your pricing, your message, or who you are selling to. The founders who win are not the ones who hear fewer no's. They are the ones who learn faster from the ones they hear.

Key idea: The goal of early-stage selling is not just revenue. It is *learning*. Every "no" that teaches you why is worth more than a "yes" you don't understand. Treat your first 50 sales conversations as paid research.

It is not about you (really)

The first thing to fix is the feeling, because the feeling is what makes you avoid the phone. When someone says no, your brain tells a story: *"They rejected me. I'm bad at this. Maybe the whole idea is bad."* That story is almost always false.

Sales trainers say this so often it is a cliché, but it is true: **they are saying no to the offer, not to you**. A "no" is a verdict on a package of things — your price, your timing, your messaging, the fit — not a verdict on your worth as a person. There is nothing wrong with *you*. There may be something wrong with the offer, and that is fixable.

Analogy: Think of a key that doesn't open a door. You don't conclude "I am a failure as a human." You think "wrong key for this lock." A "no" means this offer was the wrong key for this person, right now. You go cut a better key. The lock told you something about its shape — that's a gift.

Common mistake: Taking each "no" as a referendum on your idea. One person's no tells you very little. *Ten* no's for the *same reason* tells you everything. Never make a big decision off a single rejection — collect the pattern first.

The four kinds of "no" — and what each one teaches

"No" is not one thing. Sales people separate true **objections** (the person *could* buy but decided not to, for a specific reason) from **stalls** (a vague "let me think about it," which really means "I'm not sold yet"). For a founder, it helps to sort every no into one of four buckets. Each one points at a different fix.

The "no" you hear	What it really means	What it teaches you
"Not now" ("Call me next quarter," "We're swamped")	Timing. The pain isn't urgent enough today.	Maybe a real future buyer — or maybe the problem isn't painful enough. Probe which.
"Not you" (they pick a competitor or build it themselves)	Trust or credibility gap, or a feature gap.	What does the winner have that you don't? Proof, a feature, a reputation?
"Not a fit" ("This isn't for companies like us")	Wrong target customer (wrong "ICP").	You may be talking to the wrong people. Adjust <i>who</i> you call, not the pitch.
"Not convinced" ("Too expensive," "I don't get the value")	Value didn't land. A messaging or pricing problem.	Your story isn't connecting the product to a pain they feel.

ICP means **Ideal Customer Profile** — a short description of the exact kind of customer you serve best. "Not a fit" no's are gold: they save you from chasing people who would never have bought.

Best practice: A price objection is almost never really about price. Win-loss researchers say it the same way every time: when you hear "too expensive," dig deeper. Usually it means "I don't yet see enough value to justify this." That is a *message* problem you can fix, not a number problem.

How to ask for the real reason — without being pushy

This is the single most valuable skill in this chapter. When someone says no, your instinct is to argue them out of it. Don't. Instead, ask one calm, humble question to learn *why*. The magic is to first promise you won't fight it. That promise lowers their guard and they tell you the truth.

Example — the "I won't change your mind" ask:

"Totally understand, and I really appreciate you taking the time. I promise I'm not going to try to change your mind. But it would honestly help me a lot to understand — what made this a *no* for you? Anything you share helps me build something better."

Notice what that does. It gives them permission to be blunt. People protect your feelings and lie a little (this is the core warning of *The Mom Test* by Rob Fitzpatrick — everyone softens the truth to be nice). When you remove the pressure, the soft "it's just not the right time" often becomes the real reason: "Honestly? Your setup looked like a week of work and I don't have that week."

If the first answer is vague, gently ask "why" again. Sales researchers call this **laddering** or the **Five Whys** — each "why" climbs one rung closer to the real driver.

Example — laddering past the surface answer:

Them: "It's a bit pricey."

You: "Fair enough. Just so I learn — pricey compared to what? Another tool, or compared to what you expected it'd be worth?"

Them: "Compared to what I expected. I wasn't sure it'd actually save me time."

You (to yourself): *Not a price problem. A value-proof problem. I need a clearer before/after.*

Common mistake: Hearing the first reason and stopping. The first reason is usually the polite one. The real reason is one or two "whys" deeper. Keep your tone curious, never defensive.

Keep the door open

A "no" today is rarely a "no" forever. Timing changes. Budgets free up. So you close every lost conversation by leaving the door wide open — graciously, with zero pressure.

Example — the gracious door-open close:

"That makes total sense, and I respect the decision. I'm not going anywhere — if your situation changes or you ever want to revisit, just reply to this email and I'll jump on it. And thanks again, your feedback genuinely shaped what I work on next."

Then actually follow up. A short, no-pressure note a few weeks later — sharing something useful, not begging — keeps you in their mind. Many "no's" quietly become "yes's" three months later for the founder who stayed warm and human.

Track your reasons-for-loss to find the pattern

Here is where a founder beats a polished salesperson: you can see *the whole board*. One rep dreads rejections; you can mine them. The trick is simple — write down every no and its real reason in one place. After 10 to 20, patterns scream at you.

LOG EVERY NO -> TAG THE REASON -> COUNT -> FIX THE TOP ONE

Who	Real reason (your bucket)	Tag
Maria, bakery	"setup looked like a week"	product
Tom, agency	"didn't trust a new tool"	trust/proof
Priya, printer	"boss handles software buys"	wrong person
Dan, studio	"didn't see time saved"	messaging
Lena, retailer	"boss handles software buys"	wrong person

PATTERN: 2 of 5 = wrong person -> I'm pitching the wrong job title. Fix WHO I call, not WHAT I say.

A spreadsheet with three columns — name, what they said, your tag — is enough. There is a real case of a rep who tracked every rejection for six months and discovered 73% came from people who weren't even the decision-maker. The fix wasn't a better pitch; it was calling different people. You can't see that from one no. You can see it from the log.

Best practice: Review your loss log every Friday. Ask one question: "What is the *most common* reason, and what's the smallest change that would shrink it next week?" That single habit turns rejection into a steadily improving product and pitch.

Building a thick skin: resilience habits

Skill helps, but you also need to protect your energy so you keep going. A few habits that work:

- **Separate self-worth from outcome.** Your value as a person is fixed. The deal outcome is not about it. Say it out loud after a no: "That was about the fit, not about me."
- **Celebrate activity, not just wins.** You can't control who says yes. You *can* control how many conversations you have. Set a goal like "10 real conversations this week" and celebrate hitting it, win or lose. This is the famous Sara Blakely lesson — her dad asked at dinner, "What did you fail at this week?" and celebrated the trying.
- **Reframe the score.** If 1 in 5 buys, then each "no" is literally getting you closer to the "yes." Four no's aren't failure; they're the toll on the road to the sale.
- **Don't decide anything emotional right after a no.** Feel it for ten minutes, then look at the log, not the wound.

"Sell by chatting" — desensitize yourself on purpose

The fear of "no" is bigger than any actual "no." The way out is exposure: hear so many no's that they stop hurting. Jia Jiang, terrified of rejection, spent **100 days deliberately seeking rejection** — asking strangers for odd favors (he once asked Krispy Kreme to make donuts shaped like the Olympic rings — and they did). His big discovery: about half his "crazy" requests got a yes, and the no's didn't kill him. The fear shrank.

You don't need 100 days. Just make the early conversations low-stakes. Don't "pitch" — *chat*. Tell people you're building something and you're trying to learn, not sell. The pressure drops for both of you, and "no" stops feeling like a verdict.

Example — the low-pressure "sell by chatting" opener:

"I'm building a tool for small print shops and I'm honestly more interested in learning than selling right now. Could I show you what I've got for five minutes and hear what you think — even if it's that it's useless to you?"

You're in good company

Every "no" you hear has been heard by people who went on to win big. J.K. Rowling's Harry Potter was rejected by 12 publishers before Bloomsbury said yes. Colonel Sanders was turned down by over a thousand restaurants before one bought his recipe — at age 65. Sara Blakely sold fax machines door-to-door for seven years of constant rejection before Spanx. The rejection wasn't the opposite of their success. It was the path to it.

Key takeaways

- A "no" rejects the *offer*, not you — it's data, not damage. The goal of early sales is learning as much as revenue.
- Sort every no into "not now," "not you," "not a fit," or "not convinced" — each points to a different fix (timing, trust, target, or message).
- "Too expensive" almost always means "I don't see the value yet" — dig deeper instead of dropping the price.
- Ask the real reason with "I won't try to change your mind, but it'd really help me to understand what made this a no," then ask "why" again to ladder past the polite answer.
- Always close by keeping the door open and following up warmly later — many no's become yes's with time.
- Log every no and its real reason; review weekly. The *pattern* across 10–20 no's tells you what to fix; one no tells you almost nothing.
- Protect yourself: separate self-worth from outcome, celebrate activity over wins, and desensitize by "selling through chatting" — exposure shrinks the fear.

12. Founder-Led Outreach: Getting the Conversations

In the early days, nobody sells your product better than you. Not because you are a smooth talker. You almost certainly are not, and that is fine. You sell best because you care the most and you understand the product completely. This chapter is about the very first step of selling: getting another human to actually talk with you. We call this **outreach** — the act of reaching out to a person to start a conversation. And we call it **founder-led** because *you*, the founder, do it yourself, by hand, one message at a time.

Key idea: Your job right now is not to close deals. It is to start conversations. If you fill your calendar with real conversations, sales follow. An empty calendar is the only thing you should fear.

Paul Graham, co-founder of the startup accelerator Y Combinator, wrote a famous essay called "*Do Things That Don't Scale*." A **startup accelerator** is a program that funds and coaches very young companies. To **scale** means to grow without much extra effort per customer. His point: at the start, do the opposite. Recruit your first users *manually*, one by one, even if it feels slow and unglamorous. The Airbnb founders flew to New York and photographed hosts' apartments themselves. The Stripe founders, when someone showed interest, would say "give me your laptop" and set them up on the spot. That is founder-led outreach. It does not scale, and that is exactly why it works.

The order of channels: warm first, always

A **channel** is just a path you use to reach people. There are three, and you should work them in this order, because each is harder and colder than the last.

```
WARMEST  -> warm intros    (someone you know vouches for you) BEST
|
|          communities    (you show up where they already are)
COLDEST  -> cold outreach  (a stranger, email or DM)
```

Start warm. A **warm intro** (introduction) is when a person who knows you both connects you to someone you want to meet. It is the highest-converting path by far. **Convert** here means "turns into a real reply or meeting." People trust a recommendation from someone they know far more than any message from a stranger. So before you email a single stranger, drain your network dry.

How to ask for a warm intro (the right way)

There is a polite standard for this called the **double opt-in intro**, popularized by investor Fred Wilson. **Opt-in** means "agreeing to take part." Double opt-in means: before your connector introduces you, they first check that *both* sides actually want the intro. Nobody gets ambushed.

The golden rule: **do the work for your connector**. Write a short, copy-paste blurb they can forward without editing a word. Never make a busy friend compose an email on your behalf.

Example — asking a friend for an intro:

"Hi Sam — quick favor, and a totally easy no if it's awkward. I'm building a tool that helps small print shops manage online orders. I saw you're connected to Priya at QuickPrint. Would you be open to introducing us? I'd love 20 minutes to learn how shops like hers handle orders today — I'm not selling anything, just learning. I've written a short blurb below you can forward as-is. And if now's not a good time, no worries at all.

[Forwardable blurb] Priya — I'd like you to meet Alex, a founder building order-management software for print shops. Alex is talking to shop owners to understand how they work today and would value 20 minutes of your time. No sales pitch. Open to it?"

Notice three things. You gave an easy way to say no ("totally easy no"). You wrote the forwardable part yourself. And your ask was a *conversation*, not a purchase. That last point is the heart of this whole chapter.

"Ask for advice, not a sale" — the discovery angle

This idea comes from Rob Fitzpatrick's short, brilliant book *The Mom Test*. The title comes from a simple truth: even your mom will lie to you to protect your feelings if you ask "Do you like my idea?" People are nice. They tell you what you want to hear. That false praise feels great and teaches you nothing.

The fix: stop pitching, and start asking about *their life*. Ask about what they actually do today, not what they think of your idea. **Customer discovery** — the work of learning your customers' real problems before you sell — runs entirely on this.

Weak question (invites lies)	Strong question (gets the truth)
"Would you buy this?"	"Tell me about the last time you faced this. What did you do?"
"Do you think this is a good idea?"	"Why do you bother doing it this way at all?"
"How much would you pay?"	"How are you solving it today, and what does that cost you?"

Best practice: Lead your outreach with a genuine request to *learn*, not to *sell*. "I'd love to learn how you handle X" gets far more yeses than "Can I show you my product?" — and it makes you a better founder, because you actually find out if your idea is right.

Common mistake: Hiding a sales pitch inside a fake "I just want feedback" email, then springing a demo on the call. People feel the bait-and-switch and trust evaporates. If you say you want to learn, genuinely want to learn. The sale, when it's a real fit, comes later and easier.

Cold outreach done well

Cold outreach means contacting a stranger who has never heard of you — by email or by a direct message on a platform like LinkedIn (a **DM**, short for direct message). It is harder than warm intros, but you will run out of warm intros, so you must learn it. The honest truth about cold email today: average reply rates have fallen, from roughly 8.5% in 2019 to around 3.4% by 2026. But that average is dragged down by lazy, generic blasts. Messages with real, specific personalization can hit 18% — more than five times the average. Quality is everything.

A good cold message follows five rules. Memorize them.

1. **Research.** Know one real, specific thing about them or their business before you write. This is the difference between 3% and 18%.
2. **Make it about THEM, not you.** Your reader cares about their problems, not your features. Open with their world.
3. **Be short.** Under ~100 words. Three sentences if you can: a personal hook, a one-line reason, a small ask. A wall of text gets deleted.
4. **One clear ask.** Ask for exactly one thing. Confused readers do nothing.
5. **Soft call-to-action (CTA).** A **CTA** is the action you want them to take. Make it tiny: a conversation, not a contract. "Open to a quick 15-minute chat?" beats "Book a demo to discuss pricing."

Example — a cold discovery email:

Subject: quick question about QuickPrint's online orders

"Hi Priya,

I saw QuickPrint just added online ordering on your site — nice. I'm a founder researching how print shops handle the back-and-forth of custom orders (proofs, revisions, approvals), and you clearly do this at volume.

Would you be open to a 15-minute call so I can learn how it actually works for you? Genuinely just learning — no pitch.

Either way, love what you're building.

Alex"

Short. About her. One ask. Soft CTA. No product dump. For a LinkedIn DM, go even shorter.

Example — a LinkedIn DM:

"Hi Priya — saw QuickPrint added online ordering, impressive. I'm a founder learning how print shops handle custom-order revisions today. Would you be up for a quick 15-min chat? Purely to learn, not a pitch. Thanks either way!"

Communities, events, and showing up

You do not have to interrupt strangers cold. You can go where your customers already gather: industry forums, Facebook or Slack groups, subreddits, trade associations, local meetups, conferences. The move here is **not** to spam your link. It is to be genuinely helpful — answer questions, share what you know, be a real member. Trust builds, and conversations come to you. This is "do things that don't scale" again: it is slow, human, and it works.

Analogy: Outreach is like planting a garden, not buying flowers. A warm intro is borrowing fruit from a neighbor's mature tree — fast and sweet. Cold email is planting seeds in rocky soil — most won't sprout, so you plant many and tend the few that do. Communities are tending a plot over a whole season — slow, but eventually it feeds you reliably.

Personalization vs. volume

There is a constant tension: send *many* generic messages, or *few* tailored ones? As a founder doing discovery, choose tailored. Trigger-based personalization — referencing a real recent event like a launch, a new hire, or a funding round — outperforms a generic mail-merge by roughly 4x. Twenty hand-crafted messages will beat two hundred copy-pasted ones, and you'll learn vastly more from the replies. Volume is a later, hire-a-team problem. Right now, personalize.

Deliverability basics (so you don't get marked as spam)

Deliverability means whether your email actually lands in someone's inbox instead of their spam folder. At founder scale — a handful of careful emails a day from your normal work account — you mostly just need to not *act* like a spammer: write to real people, keep it personal, don't blast hundreds at once. A few high-level basics, in plain terms:

- **Authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC).** These are settings on your domain that prove your email is really from you. Think of them as a verified ID badge for your emails. Have your developer or email provider switch them on once; mailbox providers increasingly require them.
- **Warm up new domains slowly.** If you buy a brand-new domain to send from, don't fire off 200 emails on day one. Ramp up over weeks. A sudden burst from a fresh domain screams "spammer."
- **Keep it clean.** Don't email bad addresses (high bounces hurt you), and never trick people into opening — spam complaints above ~0.1% damage your reputation.

Best practice: At true founder scale, the simplest safe move is to send personal, one-to-one emails from your everyday business account. Personal messages to real prospects rarely trip spam filters. Save the dedicated cold-email tooling and domain-warmup machinery for when you're sending at real volume.

Following up without nagging

Most replies come from follow-ups, not the first email. People are busy and forget — silence usually means "not now," not "no." The data is clear: sending 4–7 touches across a sequence can *triple* replies versus sending just one. But there's a ceiling: past ~7 touches you generate more annoyance than replies. A **sequence** is just your planned series of messages.

Two rules keep you persistent without being a pest. First, use a **widening gap**: wait a little after the first nudge, then a bit longer each time. A 4-day gap beats a 1-day gap by nearly 2x on replies. Second, **never just repeat yourself** — add a fresh angle or a small new piece of value each time, and end with a graceful goodbye.

```
Email 1 (day 0)  the ask
Email 2 (day 3)  light bump, "floating this up"
Email 3 (day 8)  NEW value: an insight or relevant note
Email 4 (day 16) the polite breakup
```

Example — the gentle bump (Email 2):

"Hi Priya — just floating this back to the top of your inbox in case it slipped by. Totally fine if now's not the time. — Alex"

Example — the polite breakup (final email):

"Hi Priya — I don't want to clutter your inbox, so this is my last note on it. If learning how QuickPrint handles custom orders is ever worth 15 minutes, my door's open. Either way, I'll keep cheering you on. — Alex"

The breakup email is quietly powerful. By gracefully bowing out, you remove the pressure — and a surprising number of people reply precisely *because* you stopped pushing. If they still don't answer, that's fine. Archive them and re-approach in a couple of months if the fit is strong. No hard feelings, no nagging, relationship intact.

Key takeaways

- Your one job early on is to **start conversations**, not close deals — founder-led, by hand, and "do things that don't scale."
- Work channels warmest-first: **warm intros** beat communities beat cold outreach. Drain your network before emailing strangers.

- Ask using the **double opt-in** and write the forwardable blurb yourself — make it effortless for your connector and easy to say no.
- **Ask for advice, not a sale** (The Mom Test): ask about their real life and current behavior, not their opinion of your idea.
- Great cold messages are **researched, about THEM, short, one clear ask, and a soft CTA** — quality crushes volume at this stage.
- Show up genuinely in **communities**, and protect deliverability by sending personal emails from your real account, not spammy blasts.
- **Follow up 3–4 times** with a widening gap and fresh value each time; finish with a gracious breakup, then stop.

13. From Conversation to Commitment: Advancing and Closing

Let's start by saying the quiet part out loud. The word *closing* probably makes you feel a little sick. It sounds like the moment you turn into a pushy car salesperson. It sounds like a trick you do *to* someone. If that's how you feel, you are a normal, decent human being. And you are also wrong about what closing actually is.

Let me give you a new definition that you can keep for life.

Key idea: Closing means helping someone act on a decision that is good for them. It is the natural, kind ending of a helpful conversation, not a trick you play. If your product genuinely solves their problem, NOT helping them decide is the unkind thing.

Throughout this book we've talked about discovery, listening, and finding real problems. Closing is just the last step: you've helped them see they have a problem, you've shown your product fits, and now you simply help them take the next action. That's it. If you do the earlier steps well, closing feels light.

The most important habit: Always Be Advancing

You may have heard the old phrase "Always Be Closing" (from the movie *Glengarry Glen Ross*). Forget it. It teaches you to push for the sale on every breath. Here is the better idea, and it comes straight from **Neil Rackham's** research in *SPIN Selling*, the most-studied sales book ever written.

Rackham found that every sales conversation ends in one of four ways:

1. **Order** — they buy. Great, but rare in a single conversation for bigger sales.
2. **Advance** — the buyer agrees to a real action that moves things forward.
3. **Continuation** — the call ends warm and friendly but with no agreed action. This *feels* good but is going nowhere.
4. **No-sale** — a clear no.

Your job in almost every conversation is to earn an **advance**. So your new motto is **Always Be Advancing**: never end a conversation without a clear, specific, mutually-agreed next step.

Here is the crucial difference between an advance and a continuation, because it's where founders fool themselves.

Continuation (a polite stall)	Advance (real progress)
"Send me some more info."	"Let's book 30 minutes Thursday to set up a trial."
"I'll think it over and circle back."	"I'll get you the data by Friday; you'll review it with your partner Monday."
"Sounds great, keep me posted."	"I'll introduce you to our finance lead next week."

Common mistake: Treating "send me more info" as a buying signal. It usually isn't. As Rackham noted, that request puts *all* the work on you and asks *nothing* of the buyer. A truly interested buyer agrees to do some work too. If they won't lift a finger, you have a continuation, not an advance.

Conversation ends -> which of these did you get?

```
ORDER ..... they bought           (best, rare)
ADVANCE ..... agreed next step + date (your real goal)
CONTINUATION .. "let's stay in touch" (feels nice, goes nowhere)
NO-SALE ..... a clear no           (honest, frees you up)
```

A clear NO beats a warm CONTINUATION. You can act on a no.

Take the temperature first: trial closes

Before you ask for anything big, you want to know where they stand. A **trial close** is a gentle question that checks the "temperature" of the conversation without asking for a commitment. It tells you if you're ready to move forward, or if a hidden worry is still hiding.

Trial closes are easy and not scary. Sprinkle them in after you explain something. Copy any of these:

- "How does that sound so far?"
- "Does this look like it would fit how your team works?"
- "Of everything we've covered, what stands out most to you?"
- "On a scale of 1 to 10, how good a fit does this feel right now?" (Then the magic follow-up: "What would make it a 9 or 10?")

Best practice: The "1 to 10" question is gold for nervous founders. If they say "7," you don't argue — you ask what's missing from the other 3. They will hand you the exact objection you need to solve before closing. Research on top sellers shows they use trial closes far more often than weaker sellers; it's a quiet superpower.

Summarize the value, then ask

Right before you ask for the commitment, do a short recap. This makes the "yes" feel obvious because *they* said these things, not you.

Example (the summary-then-ask):

"So just to make sure I've got it right — you told me invoices take your team about six hours a week, it's causing late payments, and you'd love that time back before the busy season. What we built handles exactly that. Does that match how you see it?" (*they say yes*) "Great. Then the natural next step is to get you set up so you feel it for real. Shall we do that?"

Notice the shape: **confirm the problem** → **confirm the fit** → **ask for the next step**. The ask at the end is small and natural because you laid the path.

How to actually ask — plainly, with no pressure

Here's the secret that surprises every nervous founder: asking directly is *kinder* than hinting. Vague hints make the other person guess what you want. A clear, calm ask respects their time. You are allowed to say what you want.

Copy these. They are simple on purpose:

- "Would you like to go ahead?"
- "What would you like to do next?"
- "Should we get you started?"
- "Are you ready to move forward, or is there something still in the way?"
- "It sounds like this is a fit. Do you want to set it up today?"

Analogy: Asking for the next step is like offering your arm to someone who wants to cross a busy street. They've decided they want to cross — you can see it. Offering your arm isn't pushy; it's the helpful thing to do. Standing there silently, hoping they cross on their own, just leaves them stuck at the curb.

Then — and this is the hard part — be quiet

After you ask, **stop talking**. Let the silence sit. This is the single most common place founders blow it: they ask, feel two seconds of awkward silence, panic, and start talking again — often talking the customer *out* of it or piling on new info that creates new doubts.

Common mistake: Filling the silence after your ask. People need around **8 to 10 seconds** just to start forming an answer to an important question. Most sellers crack after 2 or 3. Count slowly in your head. Whoever speaks first often "loses" — so let it be them.

Best practice: On a video or phone call, ask your closing question, then physically take a sip of water. It forces you to be quiet and gives your hands something to do. Silence feels long to you and totally normal to them.

Soft closes that lower the stakes: the pilot

For bigger or scarier decisions, you don't have to ask for the whole commitment at once. You can offer a **pilot** — a small, time-boxed first project to prove it works. This is a "soft close": a real yes, but a small one.

Whenever you can, make it a **paid pilot**, even at a tiny price. This feels backwards to founders desperate for validation, but it matters enormously.

Key idea: A paid pilot is the cleanest signal a customer truly cares. It's far easier for someone to say "sure, I'll try it for free" than to admit "no, not at any price." Even a token fee changes how seriously they show up. Industry guidance is clear: free enterprise trials convert poorly (often under 10%), while well-scoped paid pilots can convert to full contracts at much higher rates. Charge *something* — the point isn't profit, it's skin in the game.

Example (paid-pilot soft close):

"Instead of a big commitment, let's do a focused 30-day pilot with your one busiest team. We'll agree up front on what 'success' looks like — say, cutting that invoicing time in half. It's [small price] so we both take it seriously. If we hit the goal, we talk about rolling it out. If we don't, you walk away. Fair?"

Notice two things: a written **success metric**, and a stated **next step if it works**. Without those, a pilot drags on forever and proves nothing.

For longer deals: the mutual action plan

When a sale has several steps (a demo, a security review, a contract), use a **Mutual Action Plan** (MAP) — a short shared document listing the steps, who does each one, and the dates, agreed by *both* of you. It comes from frameworks like **MEDDIC**, used in serious B2B sales, but it's just common sense: write down the path to "yes" together.

Example (introducing a MAP):

"To make this easy on you, can I send a simple one-page plan with the few steps to get from here to live, with dates? That way nothing falls through the cracks and you can see exactly what's involved. Who else on your side should be on it?"

This quietly does the hardest sales work for you: it surfaces hidden steps, hidden people, and the real timeline — without you nagging.

Honest urgency, never fake scarcity

Urgency helps people act. But there are two kinds, and one of them will destroy your reputation.

Honest urgency (use this)	Fake scarcity (never)
"Every week of delay is ~6 hours your team loses — that's the real cost of waiting."	"Only 2 spots left!" (when there aren't)
"You said you want this in before busy season; to make that, we'd start by the 15th."	"This price disappears at midnight!" (it doesn't)
"This pilot price is for our first 5 design partners, and that's genuinely true."	A countdown timer that resets when you reload.

Common mistake: Inventing pressure. Modern buyers have seen every trick. The moment they catch one fake "deadline," they stop trusting everything else you say — and that damage is permanent. Real urgency comes from *their* cost of waiting, which you uncovered in discovery. Use that.

Handling "let me think about it"

This is the most common soft-no, and it almost always hides a specific worry. Your job is not to push — it's to gently find the real concern. Don't let them go off and "think" alone, where doubts grow in the dark.

Example (the warm probe):

Them: "Let me think about it."

You: "Of course — this should be a confident yes, not a maybe. Just so I understand, when you say think about it, is it the price, the timing, or whether it'll actually work for your team?"

(They almost always name the real one.)

You: "Got it — that's totally fair. Can we look at that piece together right now, while I'm here to answer it?"

You're not arguing. You're offering to solve the exact thing standing in their way. If after that they still want time, that's fine — but now you *advance* it: "Makes sense. Let's put 15 minutes on the calendar for Thursday so I can answer anything that comes up while you think. Does morning or afternoon work?" A think-about-it with a booked follow-up is an advance. Without one, it's a stall.

The unglamorous secret: follow through

Most deals are lost not to a competitor but to silence — a founder who got a "yes, let's do the pilot" and then took five days to send the agreement, by which point the customer's excitement cooled. Speed signals that you'll be a reliable partner.

Best practice: Within an hour of any good conversation, send a short recap email: what you agreed, the next step, who does what, and the date. End with one tiny question that needs a reply ("Does Thursday 10am still work?"). This locks in the advance and gives them an easy yes to send.

That's the whole art. Help them see the problem. Show the fit. Check the temperature. Ask plainly. Be quiet. Offer a small, honest next step. Write it down. Follow through fast. None of that is a trick. All of it is service.

Key takeaways

- **Closing = helping someone act on a good decision.** If your product truly helps, NOT closing is the unkind choice.
- **Always Be Advancing.** End every conversation with a specific, mutually-agreed next step and date — an *advance*, not a feel-good *continuation*.
- **Use trial closes** ("How does that sound?", "1 to 10, then what'd make it a 9?") to read the temperature and surface hidden objections early.
- **Ask plainly, then go silent.** A clear, calm ask is kinder than hinting; people need 8–10 seconds to answer, so don't fill the gap.
- **Soft-close with a paid pilot** — a tiny fee gives the buyer skin in the game and converts far better than free; define a written success metric and the next step.
- **For multi-step deals, use a Mutual Action Plan** to map the path to yes together, surfacing hidden steps and people.
- **Honest urgency only** (their real cost of waiting), never fake scarcity — one caught lie kills all your trust. And **follow through fast** with a same-day recap email.

14. Building the Muscle: Process, Pipeline, Habit

By now you know how to talk to customers, run a discovery call, give a demo, and handle a "no." But knowing a thing once is not the same as doing it reliably. This chapter is about turning selling from a thing you do when you remember, into a **habit** you do on a schedule. We will build a simple process, a place to track deals, the few numbers worth watching, and a 30-day plan to make it stick.

Key idea: Talent is not what makes a founder good at sales. *Reps* do — a small number of selling actions, repeated on a schedule, reviewed honestly. Sales is a muscle. You build it the boring way: a little, often.

Analogy: Think of sales like going to the gym. One heroic 4-hour workout once a month leaves you sore and no stronger. Twenty minutes, most days, for a year, changes your whole body. Selling is the same. The founders who win are not the most charming. They are the most *consistent*.

What a "sales process" actually means

A **sales process** is just the named steps a deal passes through, from "stranger" to "customer." Writing them down does two things: it tells you what to do next with each person, and it shows you where deals get stuck so you can fix that one spot.

Here is a simple set of stages that works well for a solo founder. (A "stage" is one step a deal sits in until it moves forward.)

LEAD → CONTACTED → DISCOVERY → DEMO/EVAL → PROPOSAL → CLOSED
(fits your ICP) (you've reached out) (you've confirmed the problem) (they've tried/seen it works) (price & terms are out) (WON or LOST)

Lead

A person or company that matches your ideal customer. No contact yet.

Contacted

You sent the first message. Waiting to hear back.

Discovery

You had a real conversation and confirmed they have the problem you solve.

Demo / Eval

They've seen it work, or are trying it ("eval" = evaluation, a trial period).

Proposal

You've sent pricing and terms. The decision is now in their hands.

Closed

Done — either *Closed Won* (they bought) or *Closed Lost* (they didn't).

Best practice: A deal only moves to the next stage when something *real* happens — a reply, a confirmed problem, a price sent. Don't move a deal forward because you feel hopeful. "We had a nice chat" is not a stage. Hope is not a pipeline.

Your pipeline and a lightweight CRM

Your **pipeline** is simply all your live deals, sorted by which stage they're in. A **CRM** (Customer Relationship Management tool) is just the place you keep them. It sounds corporate, but for a solo founder it can literally be a spreadsheet or a free tool like a kanban board. The tool does not matter. *Having one place matters.*

Common mistake: Keeping deals in your head, in your inbox, and in scattered notes. You will forget to follow up — and forgotten follow-ups are where most early deals quietly die. The deal didn't say no. You just went silent.

Here is the **minimum** to track. Six columns. That's it.

Field	Why it matters
Who (name + company)	So you know the person, not "that one lead."
Stage	Where they are in the process (from the list above).
Next step	The single next action <i>you</i> owe them. "Send pricing." "Call back."
Next date	When you'll do it. This is the one that saves deals.
Notes	What they said, in their words. Pain, budget, who decides.
Reason lost	For dead deals — <i>why</i> . This is gold (see below).

Key idea: The two fields that matter most are **Next step** and **Next date**. Every live deal must always have both. A deal with no next step is not a deal — it's a memory. Each morning, you just sort by date and do today's row.

Why bother tracking "reason lost"? Because patterns appear. If five deals died at "too expensive," your pricing or your value story needs work. If five died at "no reply after demo," your follow-up is broken. Lost reasons turn failures into a to-do list. (Steve Blank's *customer development* idea applies here: every loss is data about your market, not just a bummer.)

Leading vs lagging indicators: track what you can control

This is the single most freeing idea in this chapter. There are two kinds of numbers.

Lagging indicator

The *result* — deals closed, revenue, customers won. It tells you about the past. You can't directly control it, and it shows up late.

Leading indicator

The *activity* that causes results — conversations booked, demos given, follow-ups sent. It happens first, and you **fully control it**.

Analogy: Revenue is your weight on the scale. You can't will the number down. But you *can* control workouts and meals — the leading indicators. Watch those daily, and the scale follows on its own. Staring at the scale every hour just makes you anxious.

Why this matters for a founder who finds selling uncomfortable: you cannot promise yourself "I'll close 3 deals this week." That's not in your hands — the customer decides. But you *can* promise "I'll book 5 conversations and send 10 outreach messages this week." That is 100% in your control. Hit your activity, and the closes come. Judge yourself on activity, not outcomes.

Best practice: Pick 2–3 leading numbers and write them where you'll see them. For an early founder: *outreach messages sent per week, conversations / calls booked per week, and follow-ups due that you actually did*. Score yourself green/red each week on those — not on revenue.

Review your calls — get better on purpose

You will not improve just by doing more calls. You improve by *looking at* your calls. Record them (with permission — a simple "I record calls so I can focus on you instead of scribbling, that okay?" works almost every time). Then once a week, listen back to one.

Don't grade everything. The teams that improve fastest pick **one or two themes per call** — feedback on ten things at once produces improvement on none. Listen for the most common founder mistake: jumping into your pitch before the buyer finished talking. (This is straight from how pros self-coach with tools like Gong and from negotiation coach Chris Voss's work on *mirroring* and *labeling* — naming what the other person feels instead of rushing to sell.)

Example — a 5-minute self-review: After listening, fill three lines:

- **One thing that worked:** "I stayed quiet after asking the budget question — they kept talking and told me the real number."
- **One thing to fix next time:** "I interrupted at 12:30 and started pitching before she finished her pain point."
- **The single change for my next call:** "Count to two in silence before I respond."

That's it. One fix per call. Twenty calls = twenty improvements.

Build the daily & weekly habit

A process is useless if you don't run it. The trick is to make the reps *small* and *scheduled*, so they happen even on a bad day. Y Combinator's famous advice is "do things that don't scale" and "talk to your users" — the founders who follow it just make it a routine, not a mood.

DAILY (20-30 min, same time)
[] Do today's "next steps"
[] Send 2-3 new outreaches
[] Log every reply in CRM

WEEKLY (45-60 min, e.g. Friday)
[] Review pipeline, update stages
[] Score leading indicators (G/R)
[] Listen to 1 call, note 1 fix
[] Mark dead deals + reason lost

Best practice: Block a fixed "sales hour" on your calendar like a meeting you can't move. Same time every day. Builders skip selling because it feels less urgent than code — a calendar block protects it from the rest of your day.

When to hand sales to a salesperson (and why not yet)

Many founders want to hire a salesperson early to escape the discomfort. Resist. **You cannot hand off a process you haven't figured out.** If you don't know what makes a deal close, a hire will just flail — and you'll blame the wrong thing.

The rule from the people who study this (Mark Roberge's *The Sales Acceleration Formula*; First Round Review; YC) is about *readiness*, not just revenue. Most B2B startups carry **founder-led sales** to somewhere between \$500K and ~\$1.5M in yearly recurring revenue, with a common median around \$1M. But the real signal is this:

Key idea: Hire your first salesperson only when *you* can run the whole motion — outreach, discovery, demo, close — and predict the result within roughly $\pm 20\%$. The metric beats the milestone: a founder at \$500K with clean, repeatable conversion is more ready than one at \$2M who can't explain why deals close. Hire a strong closer (an "AE," Account Executive) to copy your proven motion first; a sales *leader* comes later, once a second or third rep is working.

Putting the whole guide together: your personal system

Everything in this book becomes one simple loop you can run forever:

1. **Find** people who fit your ideal customer → add as *Leads*.
2. **Reach out** on your daily schedule → move to *Contacted*.
3. **Listen first** in discovery (Mom Test style — ask about their life, not your idea) → confirm real pain.
4. **Show the fix**, tied to their words, in a demo.
5. **Propose** clearly; handle objections as questions, not rejection.
6. **Log everything** — next step, next date, notes, and reason lost.

7. **Review weekly** — your numbers and one call — and fix one thing.

Common mistake: Treating this guide as something you "finished reading." The skill lives in the loop, not the pages. Re-run the chapter that matches whatever stage your deals keep dying in.

A 30-day practice plan

Week	Focus	Do this
1	Set up the system	Build the 6-column tracker. List 20 leads. Pick your 2–3 leading numbers. Block a daily sales hour.
2	Outreach reps	Send 3 outreaches/day. Log every reply. Book your first 3–5 conversations. Don't judge by closes — judge by activity.
3	Discovery + recording	Run discovery calls. Record them. Each one: note 1 win, 1 fix, 1 change for next time.
4	Move & review deals	Push deals to demo/proposal. Run your first full weekly review. Mark lost reasons. Score your leading numbers green/red.

At day 30 you won't be a "natural salesperson" — nobody is. But you'll have a running system, a handful of real conversations, and proof that the discomfort fades with reps. That's the whole game.

Key takeaways

- Sales is a muscle: small reps, on a schedule, beat occasional heroic effort.
- Use a simple 6-stage pipeline (Lead → Contacted → Discovery → Demo → Proposal → Closed); move deals only on real events, never on hope.
- Track six things per deal — the two that save you are **Next step** and **Next date**; capture **reason lost** to spot patterns.
- Judge yourself on *leading* indicators (conversations booked, outreach sent) you control — not *lagging* ones (closes) you don't.
- Record calls; review one a week; fix exactly one thing each time.
- Keep founder-led sales until you can run and predict the whole motion ($\approx \pm 20\%$) — readiness beats any revenue milestone before your first hire.
- The whole guide is one repeatable loop: find → reach → listen → show → propose → log → review.

Glossary of Terms

Active listening

Listening so closely that you can repeat back what the person meant, not just what they said. You show it by summarizing ("So the painful part is the manual re-entry, did I get that right?") and by staying quiet long enough for them to keep going.

Advance

A concrete next step that moves a deal forward, agreed to by the buyer. "Let's meet Thursday with your boss" is an advance. "Sounds great, I'll think about it" is not. The opposite of an advance is a stall.

BANT

A simple qualification checklist created at IBM: **B**udget (can they pay?), **A**uthority (can this person decide?), **N**eed (do they have the problem?), **T**imeline (when will they act?). Fast but blunt.

Brush-off

A polite, vague reason someone gives to end a conversation without committing, like "send me some info" or "let me check with the team." It usually hides a real objection you have not surfaced yet.

Champion

A person inside the customer's company who wants your product to win and will push for it when you are not in the room. The "C" in MEDDIC.

Churn

The rate at which customers stop paying you and leave. High churn means you are filling a leaky bucket; selling more does not help until the leak is fixed.

Closed question

A question answerable with one word, usually yes or no ("Do you like this?"). Useful for confirming facts, weak for learning. Compare open question.

Closing

Asking for and getting the buying decision. Not a single magic line; it is the natural end of a conversation where you have earned the right to ask.

Cold outreach

Contacting someone who has never heard of you (a cold email or message). Compare warm outreach, where there is an introduction or prior connection.

CRM

Customer Relationship Management tool, a piece of software (or even a spreadsheet) where you track every prospect, conversation, and next step so nothing falls through the cracks.

Customer development

Steve Blank's method of systematically talking to customers to test your assumptions, in four stages: discovery, validation, creation, and company-building. Summed up as "get out of the building."

Discovery call

An early conversation whose only job is to understand the other person's situation, problems, and goals, not to pitch. Good discovery makes everything after it easier.

Economic buyer

The person who controls the budget and can say final yes to spending money. The "E" in MEDDIC. Often more senior than the person you first meet.

GAP selling

An approach (from Keenan's book of the same name) built on finding the "gap" between where the customer is now (current state) and where they want to be (future state). The size of that gap is the value of solving it.

ICP (Ideal Customer Profile)

A clear description of the type of customer who needs you most, gets the most value, and is easiest to sell to and keep. Knowing your ICP tells you who to chase and who to skip.

Lead

Any person or company who might become a customer. The rawest stage. A lead becomes a prospect once you confirm basic fit.

Leading question

A question that pushes the answer you want, like "You'd pay for this, right?" People say yes to be nice, and you learn nothing true. The thing the Mom Test is built to avoid.

MEDDIC / MEDDPIC

A B2B qualification framework for bigger deals: **M**etrics, **E**conomic buyer, **D**ecision criteria, **D**ecision process, **I**dentify pain, **C**hampion (the extra PC adds Paper process and Competition). It helps you judge whether a deal is real and winnable.

The Mom Test

Rob Fitzpatrick's set of rules for customer conversations so honest that even your mom could not lie to you: talk about their life not your idea, ask about the past not the future, and talk less while you listen more.

Objection

A reason the buyer gives for not moving forward (price, timing, trust, fit). A real objection is useful information, not an attack.

Open question

A question that invites a full answer ("Walk me through how you handle that today"). Open questions do the heavy lifting in discovery.

Opportunity

A qualified prospect with a real need, budget, and intent to buy, a deal worth actively working. The stage after lead and prospect.

Pipeline

The list of all your active deals, organized by stage (from first contact to closed). Your pipeline shows what is coming and where things are stuck.

Problem-solution fit

The point where you have proof that a real problem exists and your proposed solution addresses it. It comes before product-market fit.

Product-market fit

The point where a real market clearly wants your actual product, shown by people buying, using, and staying. The goal of early-stage selling and customer development.

Prospect

A lead you have confirmed is a plausible fit and worth a conversation. Between lead and opportunity.

Qualification

Deciding whether a prospect is worth your limited time, based on fit, need, ability to buy, and timing. Saying no to bad fits is as valuable as saying yes to good ones.

SPIN

Neil Rackham's question sequence, drawn from analyzing 35,000 sales calls: **S**ituation, **P**roblem, **I**mplication, **N**eed-payoff. You move from facts, to pains, to the cost of those pains, to the value of fixing them.

Trial close

A small, low-pressure check on how the buyer is feeling before you ask for the full commitment, like "How does this sound so far?" It tells you whether to keep going or address a concern.

Value vs features

A feature is what your product *has* ("exports to CSV"); value is what it *does for the customer* ("you stop spending Friday afternoons copying data by hand"). Buyers pay for value.

Warm outreach

Reaching out where there is already a connection, a referral, a mutual contact, or someone who engaged with you. Far higher response rates than cold.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: I'm an introvert and selling makes me anxious. Can I actually do this?

Yes, and introverts often become excellent at it. The best discovery is mostly listening, and listening is an introvert's superpower. Paul Graham admitted he lacked "the smoothness of a good salesman" but won by being persistent and genuinely curious. You are not auditioning to be a smooth talker. You are being a careful detective. That role fits a quiet, thoughtful person perfectly.

Q: Isn't selling basically manipulation?

Manipulation is getting someone to do something against their interest. Good selling is the opposite: you dig hard to find out whether you can genuinely help, and if you cannot, you say so. Every framework in this guide, the Mom Test, SPIN, discovery, is built on understanding the customer, not tricking them. If you stay honest, you are not manipulating anyone. You are helping people decide.

Q: How many customer interviews are enough?

There is no magic number, but a useful rule of thumb is to keep going until you stop hearing new things, often somewhere around 10 to 20 conversations per customer type. The goal is patterns, not a quota. When the fifth person describes the same painful workflow in almost the same words, you are onto something real. When everyone says something different, keep talking.

Q: I have no network and no warm intros. Where do I even find people to talk to?

Start where your customers already gather. Online communities, subreddits, LinkedIn groups, industry Slack channels, and local meetups. Reach out with a genuine, specific message asking to learn, not to sell ("I'm researching how small print shops handle X, could I ask you a few questions for 15 minutes?"). The Airbnb founders literally knocked on doors. Doing things that don't scale is normal and expected at the start.

Q: Should I talk about price early?

In early customer development, your goal is learning, so do not pitch price; instead learn what the problem currently costs them (in time, money, or frustration) and whether they have ever paid to solve it. Once you are genuinely selling, do not hide price until the end either. Surface it naturally once value is clear, so you do not waste anyone's time. A real budget conversation is part of honest qualification, not a dirty trick.

Q: What if they ask for a feature I don't have?

Get curious before you promise. Ask "What would that let you do that you can't today?" Often the request points to a deeper need you can already meet, or one you should build. Never invent a fake "yes, it does that." A short honest "not yet, tell me more about why that matters" builds more trust than a hollow promise you cannot keep.

Q: People say "this is great!" but never buy. What's going on?

Compliments are the most dangerous feedback there is, because they feel good and mean nothing. This is the exact trap the Mom Test was written to fix. Stop asking whether they like your idea. Ask about what they actually do today, what they have already tried, and what they have spent money on. Behavior in the past predicts buying; enthusiasm about the future does not.

Q: How do I handle "send me some info" or "let me think about it"?

Those are usually brush-offs hiding a real concern. Gently dig: "Happy to. So I send the right thing, what's the main question on your mind?" or "Totally fair, what would you want to feel sure about before deciding?" You are not pushing; you are surfacing the real objection so you can address it honestly or walk away cleanly.

Q: When should I hire a salesperson?

Not yet. The founder should do sales until you can clearly explain who buys, why, what objections come up, and what it takes to close, roughly until you have repeatable wins and early product-market fit. If you hand selling to someone else before you understand it yourself, you will not be able to coach them, and you will lose your richest source of product feedback.

Q: I'm worried I'll freeze or say something dumb on a call. Any safety net?

Two things. First, prepare three questions you most want answered and keep them on screen; you will never be lost. Second, remember silence is allowed. After you ask a question, count to three in your head and let them fill the space. Most "dumb" moments come from rushing to fill silence, not from listening.

Q: What's the difference between customer development and just selling?

Customer development is learning whether you have something worth selling; selling is getting people to buy it. Early on they blur together, which is fine. The same conversation can teach you about the problem and end in a sale. Just be honest with yourself about which one you are doing, so you do not mistake a friendly chat for proof that your business works.

Q: How do I stay motivated when most people say no?

Reframe "no" as data, not rejection. Every no teaches you who your product is not for, or which objection to fix. Track your numbers; when you see that, say, one in eight conversations becomes a customer, each no literally moves you closer to the next yes. Rejection stings less when it is just part of a known process.

Q: Do I need a CRM and a fancy process from day one?

No. A simple spreadsheet with columns for name, last contact, stage, and next step is plenty for your first dozens of deals. The discipline matters more than the tool: always know the next step for every conversation. Add real CRM software once the spreadsheet starts to hurt, not before.

Revision Cheat Sheet

Reread this in the five minutes before any customer call. It pulls the whole guide into one page.

The Mom Test, the 3 rules

1. Talk about **their life**, not your idea.
2. Ask about **the past and specifics**, not opinions about the future.
3. **Talk less, listen more** (aim to let them speak ~80% of the time).

Key idea: Compliments and "I would totally buy that" are not data. Past behavior and money already spent are data.

Good questions vs bad questions

Bad (leading / hypothetical)	Good (real / past)
"Do you think this is a good idea?"	"Walk me through the last time you faced this."
"Would you pay for this?"	"What do you use today, and what does it cost you?"
"Wouldn't it be great if...?"	"How are you solving it right now?"
"Do you like it?"	"What have you already tried to fix this?"

Discovery-call skeleton

1. OPEN Set the frame: "Mostly want to learn about how you work today. Cool if I ask questions?"
2. SITUATION Understand their world and current process.
3. PROBLEM Find the pains and frustrations.
4. IMPACT What do those problems cost? (time/money/stress)
5. GOALS Where do they want to be instead?
6. NEXT STEP Agree on a concrete advance, with a date.

SPIN in one line each (Neil Rackham)

- **S — Situation:** facts about their current setup. "How do you handle X today?"
- **P — Problem:** the pain. "Where does that process break down?"
- **I — Implication:** the cost of the pain. "What happens when it breaks, downstream?"
- **N — Need-payoff:** let them say the value. "If that were solved, what would it mean for you?"

Objection handling, the LAARC steps

1. **Listen** fully, no interrupting.
2. **Acknowledge**: "That's a fair concern."
3. **Assess / Ask**: "Help me understand, is it the price, or whether it'll work?"
4. **Respond** honestly to the real concern.
5. **Confirm**: "Does that put it to rest?"

Best practice: Treat every objection as a question in disguise. Answer the question, not the tone.

Outreach formula (cold or warm)

[Relevance] why you, why now, specific to them
+ [Credibility] one short reason to trust you
+ [Ask] one tiny, clear request (15 min to learn)
= short message, easy yes

Example: "Hi Sam, I saw your shop does custom wedding invites. I'm researching how small print shops handle rush orders, no pitch. Could I ask you 4 quick questions for 15 minutes this week?"

Trial-close and closing lines you can say

- Trial close: "How's this sounding so far?"
- Trial close: "Is there anything that would stop this from being a fit?"
- Advance: "Makes sense to take the next step, can we set up a pilot starting Monday?"
- Close: "I think we can solve this for you. Want to get started?"
- Honest exit: "Sounds like this isn't the right time, totally fine, should I check back in a quarter?"

Qualify fast, BANT

- **B**udget, can they pay?
- **A**uthority, can this person decide (or who can)?
- **N**eed, is the problem real and felt?
- **T**imeline, when will they act?

Do / Never do

Do	Never do
Ask about the past and real behavior	Ask if they "like the idea"
Let silence work for you	Fill every pause / talk over them
Sell value (what it does for them)	List features they didn't ask about
End with a dated next step	Leave with "I'll think about it"
Write down their exact words	Trust your memory after the call
Say "no, not yet" honestly	Promise features you don't have
Walk away from bad-fit prospects	Chase everyone equally

Common mistake: Pitching during a learning call. If you came to learn, do not sell. If you came to sell, still listen first.